

ALTERING THE PATTERN:
WILLING SELF-SACRIFICE AS AN EMBODIMENT OF FREE WILL
IN GUY GAVRIEL KAY'S *THE FIONAVAR TAPESTRY*

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Samantha Storey, candidate for the degree of Master of Arts in English, has presented a thesis titled, ***Altering the Pattern: Willing Self-Sacrifice as an Embodiment of Free Will in Guy Gavriel Kay's The Fionavar Tapestry***, in an oral examination held on July 3, 2015. The following committee members have found the thesis acceptable in form and content, and that the candidate demonstrated satisfactory knowledge of the subject material.

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Abstract

This study analyzes the role of willing self-sacrifice in Guy Gavriel Kay's trilogy *The Fionavar Tapestry*. I begin by detailing anthropological studies about sacrifice which provide the critical framework for this thesis. I contrast Kay's trilogy with J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy and claim that they have fundamentally different worldviews. Tolkien's worldview is primarily providential where every act of free will only reinforces the plan. In Kay's trilogy, free will is often counter to a divine plan and acts of free will can and do alter that plan for the better. I analyze the trilogy by focusing on specific instances of willing self-sacrifice in each volume and showing how those instances either alter the divine plan, in this case *The World Tapestry*, or result in its successful completion. I draw the conclusion that Kay approaches the problem of fate and free will differently from other fantasy authors, specifically Tolkien, and that he takes a more secular approach to the ideas of sacrifice and free will.

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Dedication

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INTRODUCTION

Guy Gavriel Kay is a Canadian fantasy author, born in Weyburn, Saskatchewan, in 1954. To date, he has written twelve novels and one book of poetry. He is an internationally acclaimed author whose works have been translated into more than twenty-five languages and he has won various awards including the Aurora Award and the World Fantasy Award for Best Novel. Kay was appointed to the Order of Canada in 2014. His novels generally fall into the category of historical fantasy: he takes a particular historical moment or era and creates a secondary world that closely mirrors that era.

Kay got his start writing fiction as a young man when Christopher Tolkien asked him to help edit and assemble his father, J.R.R. Tolkien's, notes. Their combined work resulted in *The Silmarillion* (1977). With this close connection to Tolkien established, Kay went on to write his first novels, including his only trilogy, *The Fionavar Tapestry* (1984-86) (hereafter *Fionavar*). The trilogy is Kay's attempt to demonstrate that not all fantasy trilogies or series need to imitate Tolkien, though Kay is very respectful of the Tolkienian tradition. The trilogy pays homage to Tolkien and other similarities are obvious, but Kay also makes a concerted effort to distinguish his work from Tolkien's. This difference is most noticeable in the case of how sacrifice functions in *Fionavar*.

There has been a debate for centuries about the definition of sacrifice and the many forms it takes. Since sacrifice is the subject of my thesis, a brief summary of sacrifice theory will be useful here. In *The Origins of Sacrifice* (1933), E.O. James approaches the subject anthropologically and describes what beliefs and rituals various societies have in common regarding sacrifice. For example, he explains the widespread belief in pre-

modern cultures that blood offerings contain “soul-substance” (22) where “the possession of a common vitality establishes a mystic vital bond between all who share the same life-essence, and since this potency is capable of transmission from one person or object to another, renewed health and strength can be secured by a ritual transference of soul-substance” (23). Many societies, including Paleolithic tribes, according to James, held (or still hold) the idea that certain animals, plants and even inanimate objects contain soul-substance which therefore make them appropriate to be sacrificed. James states that the sacrificial ritual “is essentially an attempt to control the unpredictable element in human experience, and the means whereby the body corporate preserves its integrity and health” (25). Therefore, the ritual of sacrifice was often seen to be necessary in order to preserve the community as a whole. He later elaborates: “In the ritual shedding of blood it is not the taking of life but the giving of life that really is fundamental, for blood is not death but life. The outpouring of the vital fluid in actuality, or by substitute, is the sacred act whereby life is given to promote and preserve life, and to establish thereby a bond of union with the supernatural order” (33). James therefore connects sacrificial blood offering with religious ritual and the dealings between the natural and the supernatural world.

James provides a good introduction to the concept of sacrifice, but his predecessors Henri Hubert and Marcel Mauss in *Sacrifice: Its Nature and Function* (1898) developed one of the most influential theories about sacrifice in the nineteenth century. They began the trend of seeing violence as a key element in sacrifice, a theme that René Girard expanded upon and which I will discuss a little later. While acknowledging its complexity and variety of functions, Hubert and Mauss propose that most often sacrifice

is performed using a similar procedure: “This ... consists in establishing a means of communion between the sacred and the profane worlds through the mediation of a victim, that is, of a thing that in the course of the ceremony is destroyed” (97).

Furthermore, “the victim does not necessarily come to the sacrifice with a religious nature already perfected and clearly defined: it is the sacrifice itself that confers this upon it” (97). In addressing the idea that the profane world needs an intermediary to get in touch with the sacred, Hubert and Mauss explain that the supernatural forces embodied in religion are conceived as too powerful for ordinary men to come into direct contact with (98): “Between these powers and himself [the sacrificer] interposes intermediaries, of whom the principal is the victim. If he involved himself in the rite to the very end, he would find death, not life. The victim takes his place ... The sacrificer remains protected: the gods take the victim instead of him. *The victim redeems him*” (98). This is the notion of the necessary substitute that James touched upon and that Girard will expand upon.

Hubert and Mauss also discuss the idea of sacrifice as a social function, since every act of sacrifice according to them has “some idea of redemption” (99). Communities “find in sacrifice the means of redressing equilibriums that have been upset.... The social norm is thus maintained without danger to themselves, without diminution for the group. Thus the social function of sacrifice is fulfilled, both for the individuals and for the community” (102-3). They define sacrifice as “a religious act which, through the consecration of a victim, modifies the condition of the moral person who accomplishes it or that of certain objects with which he is concerned” (13). In this way they perceive a redemptive function in all sacrificial acts.

René Girard in his key work *Violence and the Sacred* (1977) agrees with Hubert and Mauss about the centrality of violence in sacrifice but points out a certain circular logic in their argument: “Because the victim is sacred, it is criminal to kill him – but the victim is sacred only because he is to be killed” (1). Girard, then, conceives of a definition of sacrifice rooted in the inherent violence in human beings and their societies. Violence, Girard says, “[w]hen unappeased ... seeks and always finds a surrogate victim. The creature that excited its fury is abruptly replaced by another, chosen only because it is vulnerable and close at hand” (2). This idea of the surrogate victim is crucial to Girard’s theory. Using examples from the Bible and Greek tragedies, he rejects Hubert and Mauss’s notion of sacrifice as a “mediation between a sacrifice and a ‘deity’” (6), and instead sees it as having an almost entirely social function that is merely cloaked in religious ritual. In fact, the religious ritual is necessary only so that the sacrificial process be misunderstood by those practising it: “The celebrants do not and must not comprehend the true role of the sacrificial act. The theological basis of the sacrifice has a crucial role in fostering this misunderstanding. It is the god who supposedly demands the victims; he alone, in principle, who savors the smoke from the altars and requisitions the slaughtered flesh” (7). Girard puts the theological basis of sacrifice under a critical microscope in order to expose the “societal conflicts that the sacrificial act and its theological interpretations at once dissimulate and appease” (7).

Girard draws the following conclusion from his examination of sacrifice in many societies:

The victim is not a substitute for some particularly endangered individual, nor is it offered up to some individual of particularly bloodthirsty temperament. Rather,

it is a substitute for all the members of the community, offered up by the members themselves. The sacrifice serves to protect the entire community from *its own* violence; it prompts the entire community to choose victims outside itself. The elements of dissension scattered throughout the community are drawn to the person of the sacrificial victim and eliminated, at least temporarily, by its sacrifice. (8)

The violence inherent in society can only be stemmed, at least for a time, if it is unleashed against one victim, who must die. Girard believes that the sacrificial victim, if human, must be someone with very few social ties or somehow “othered” from the community, or, if not human, must resemble humans strongly enough to be an effective sacrificial victim (11-12). The necessity that the victim be “other” is to stem the cycle of vengeance which would otherwise be initiated if a victim from the in-group (i.e. non-other) were sacrificed. Girard explains that “sacrifice is primarily an act of violence without risk of vengeance” (13). The absence for the need of sacrifice in our society Girard attributes to the judicial system, which in a way avenges the victims of violent crimes (22). Girard, then, believes that actual sacrifice is only necessary in a society that does not have a judicial system. By sacrificing a victim that is similar enough to the members of a community, but not fully a part of the community, the violent tendencies within that community are, for a time, arrested.

While Girard’s theory is compelling, there are some theorists of sacrifice who disagree with him. Kathryn McClymond, for example, in *Beyond Sacred Violence* (2008), does not believe that violence is at the root of sacrifice. She criticizes both Girard and Hubert and Mauss for their focus on the killing aspect of sacrifice:

Each of these scholars ignores or minimizes the other activities that are applied to the sacrificial offering, and in so doing they exaggerate the importance of killing, characterizing it as the essential feature of sacrificial activity. Second, all these scholars focus almost exclusively on animal offerings, rather than discussing the full complement of animal, vegetal, and liquid oblations that are used in various sacrificial rituals. (17)

McClymond takes a comparative anthropological approach to sacrifice, mainly focusing on the Jewish sacrificial tradition and Vedic sacrificial practices in Hinduism. She also declines to define sacrifice, and instead examines the properties of an event that make it sacrificial (25). She encourages the reader “not to think of rituals as either ‘sacrifice’ or ‘not sacrifice’ but rather to view some rituals as more or less sacrificial than others” (25). This approach allows her to “recognize a wide spectrum of ritual activity in which certain ritual events are more or less sacrificial than others, depending upon several criteria” (25).

The criteria that McClymond uses are divided into seven types which are “selection, association, identification, killing, heating, apportionment, and consumption” (29). She recognizes that the death of the victim is an important part in sacrificial ritual but qualifies it: “Killing gains sacrificial authority by being performed within the context of other activities, all of which reinforce one another’s sacrificial (and authoritative) status” (33). She dedicates all her second chapter to the role of killing in sacrifice. She comes to three specific conclusions in this chapter. First, “sacrificial killing is performed with plant as well as animal offerings, which raises questions about the prominence of animal offerings in sacrificial theorizing” (46); second, that “killing is not necessarily about

blood or violence” (46); and third, that “killing is often *not* a definitive or culminating activity within sacrifice” (46). I find McClymond’s theory useful in my study of *Fionavar* because in many of the sacrifices I discuss the person making the sacrifice dies but is not killed through violence.

The last theorist of sacrifice I would like to discuss is Moshe Halbertal. In *On Sacrifice* (2012), Halbertal makes an important distinction that few others have done; namely, he divides sacrifice into two categories: sacrificing to and sacrificing for (2). The second category is particularly interesting to me because it typifies the sacrifices I analyze in *Fionavar*. Halbertal describes ‘sacrificing to’ as involving “mainly the religious sphere. It engages such questions as ritual, substitution, atonement, and the ways in which different religious traditions developed complex alternatives to replace and yet replicate animal sacrifice as the main mode of worship” (2). ‘Sacrificing for,’ on the other hand, “involves different realms altogether – the political and moral spheres. Self-sacrifice for another individual, value, or collective seems key to much of ethical life and political organizations” (4). Since virtually all of the sacrifices I discuss in this thesis are acts of self-sacrifice, Halbertal’s theory will be important in what follows. His focus is mainly on “the relationship between self-sacrifice and violence ... to show the way in which misguided self-transcendence has a potential to lead to far greater evils and harms than those that are motivated by excessive self-love” (4). He looks at war as a prime example of where ‘sacrificing for’ generally takes place and investigates “the role of sacrifice in war and the function of the state as a sacrificial bond” (5).

Self-transcendence, that is, being able to think beyond ourselves, understand another's point of view, and treat others the way in which we would like to be treated, is an important aspect of 'sacrificing for'. Halbertal states:

Sacrifice's place in moral life also serves as a scale for measuring the weight of moral demands and obligations in two ways. The first scale measures the relative weight of moral obligations through examining judgments about cases in which two moral obligations clash with one another.... The second scale measures the degree of the sacrifice required for fulfilling an obligation. (64-5)

He goes on to say that "[t]his second measure allows us to rank the order of moral obligations in terms of the expected degree of personal sacrifice – for instance, the prospect of self-sacrifice in order to save someone's life compared to self-sacrifice in order to avoid killing an innocent person" (65). Interestingly, Halbertal notes that in the Jewish tradition "a person may be obligated to risk or give up his life so as not to kill an innocent person, but may not be expected to give up his life to save another" (65). The difference between these two appears to be that a person is not obliged to give their own life to save an innocent from outside forces but may do so to save that innocent from themselves. This seems to me an inversion of what is normally thought of as self-sacrifice, especially in literature: normally, the heroes are expected to sacrifice themselves to save another.

Halbertal continues: "The giving of or from the self is hailed ... as an expression of loyalty and love. Asceticism as a value is sometimes based on this concept of giving of the self. Yet one can also note how the notion of sacrifice moves beyond the giving up of desires, instincts, and goals towards the sacrifice of a moral conscience" (73). Clearly,

Halberty views self-sacrifice with suspicion as it can be too easily perverted into immoral behaviour, such as with the Nazis during World War II. Regardless, the fact that he even considers the idea of ‘sacrificing for’ different from ‘sacrificing to’ is an important insight in clarifying the nature of sacrifice.

All of the theorists I discuss above have made important contributions to the study of sacrifice. That said, there are still gaps in their theories, sometimes pointed out by the other theorists I discuss. James’ main goal is to explain sacrifice in various cultures and how sacrifice was practiced within those cultures but he does very little actually theorizing. Hubert and Mauss do develop a definition of sacrifice but, as Girard points out, it contains circular logic. Both Girard and Hubert and Mauss focus almost exclusively on the violence in sacrifice which, as McClymond points out, ignores many other relevant parts of the sacrificial ritual. All the theorists, with the exception of Halberty, also only discuss sacrifice in the context of religious ritual. This focus makes sense to a certain degree because sacrifice seems to have originated from religious practice. Halberty points out, however, that the meaning of the word has expanded in modern society and is no longer only tied to religious ritual. Halberty’s cynicism in regards to ‘sacrificing for’ seems to taint his view of the positive aspects of that idea. Those positive aspects are especially important in regards to my study of *Fionavar*. The characters that choose to sacrifice themselves in the trilogy do so mostly for the good of others.

I now want to draw attention to an article on Guy Gavriel Kay which I expand upon in this thesis. In “From Middle Earth to Fionavar: Free Will and Sacrifice in High Fantasy by J.R.R. Tolkien and Guy Gavriel Kay” (2002), Susannah Clements compares

how free will and sacrifice operate in Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* (1954-55) trilogy and in Kay's *Fionavar*. Clements discusses the significant differences in worldview between Tolkien and Kay, and notes how sacrifice plays a part in both. She emphasizes the Catholic worldview portrayed by Tolkien: his "novels always point back to some kind of sovereign will or plan for the universe – free will is the way this plan is carried out." For example, Frodo volunteers to take the Ring to Mordor, but because the Ring came to Bilbo and subsequently to Frodo himself, this event was always meant to happen. Elrond sees this as providential: "'If I understand aright all that I have heard' ... 'I think that this task is appointed for you, Frodo; and that if you do not find a way, no one will'" (Tolkien, *Fellowship* 353). In Kay, however, Clements notes that "human choice is of such value that it can sometimes [e]ffect change *despite* the Weaver's will and not because of it" (Clements). Kay particularly emphasizes the role of willing self-sacrifice in shaping the fate of characters in *Fionavar*, a theme with no direct parallel in Tolkien.

It will be useful here to briefly discuss Tolkien's notion of eucatastrophe. In the essay "On Fairy-Stories" (1947), Tolkien describes the nature of what he terms fairy-stories and their ultimate purpose. While this purpose includes recovery and escape (145), the "Consolation of the Happy Ending" (153) is most important for Tolkien. He coins the term "eucatastrophe" and defines it as "the good catastrophe, the sudden joyous 'turn' ... a sudden and miraculous grace: never to be counted on to recur" (153). He relates this term immediately to 'evangelium' which is "giving a fleeting glimpse of Joy, Joy beyond the walls of the world" (153). In the epilogue of his essay, Tolkien expands upon the ideas of eucatastrophe and evangelium in relation to "the Christian Story" (155), namely

the birth and resurrection of Jesus Christ. He calls the “Birth of Christ ... the eucatastrophe of Man’s history” and “the Resurrection ... the eucatastrophe of the story of the Incarnation” (156). Tolkien views the eucatastrophe as a glimpse of a profound truth that can reflect from the fairy-story onto reality. We can then conclude that Tolkien takes inspiration from the story of Jesus Christ and his trilogy is a reflection of what he believes: since that story had a eucatastrophe, any story that strives towards truth should also contain eucatastrophe. Gollum’s role in Tolkien’s trilogy contributes to the eucatastrophe: just as Frodo fails to destroy the Ring, Gollum appears, takes it from him, and is then destroyed along with the Ring. The Ring had to be destroyed and even when Frodo failed, an event occurred that ensured the Ring’s destruction.

Tolkien’s worldview, given the example of Gollum, seems to be providential. I now need to provide at least brief definitions of providentialism, or predestination, and foreknowledge, and the role I see free will playing in each. Providentialism is defined as the “belief that events are predestined by God or fate” (“Providentialism”). Many scholars debate free will’s role in a providentialist view of the world. Foreknowledge proves similarly problematic in terms of free will. The definition of foreknowledge is “knowledge of an event, etc. before it exists or happens; prescience” (“Foreknowledge”). But how can we have free will if God has foreknowledge and fate is predestined? In the article “Foreknowledge and Freedom” (2011), Trenton Merricks argues that “God’s beliefs depend on the world” (586) which is to say that human action influences God’s knowledge of things. He gives the following example: “Suppose I said ... at noon tomorrow, God will believe that you are then eating lunch; and, second, you have no choice about what God will believe at noon tomorrow ... you [do] have a choice about

whether you will eat lunch at noon tomorrow; whether God will believe, at noon tomorrow, that you are then eating lunch depends ... on whether you will be eating lunch then” (573). This example states that you do have a choice and God’s belief, or foreknowledge, depends on that choice. This is similar to Clements’s statement that all of the choices made in Tolkien’s trilogy make the plan happen the way it should. I argue that in Kay’s trilogy free will changes that initial plan and self-sacrifice is often the way in which this change is carried out.

The relation between self-sacrifice and the World Tapestry in Kay’s trilogy is what I aim to explore in this thesis. Specifically, I’m interested in the idea that willing self-sacrifice is necessary to the satisfactory completion of the pattern of the various worlds and the Tapestry itself. In *Fionavar*, it is clear that the figure known as The Weaver at the Loom is the Creator of not only Fionavar, the first of all worlds, but also all the worlds that are reflections of this first world, including our own.

The Weaver is constantly weaving the Tapestry and clearly has a fixed pattern in mind. Every thread has its place and is supposed to develop the pattern in a certain and specific way. One might conclude that everything in these worlds is predestined, that all the characters’ fates have already been decided, and there is nothing they can do to change them. But when we examine the role that sacrifice, especially willing self-sacrifice, has to play within the novels we find this not to be true. Middle-Earth is also similar in that it does not operate wholly according to destiny, though each choice made by the characters seems to be in accordance with a greater plan. Through the choices and actions of seven characters within *Fionavar*, fates are changed and the very pattern of the

Tapestry is altered. These changes are not easily made, however, since it is only through the difficult choice of self-sacrifice that such changes can be effected.

Each of the three volumes in the trilogy has episodes of significant willing self-sacrifice and so each chapter of my thesis will focus on one of the three volumes in order. In the first chapter, I intend to analyze the beginning of the trilogy, *The Summer Tree* (hereafter *TST*). My focus will be on the two important self-sacrifices characters make: when Ysanne the Seer kills herself with the dagger Lökdal in order to give her soul to Kimberley Ford (*TST* 133, 138); and when Paul Schafer willingly goes on the Summer Tree to die in King Ailell's place and end the drought (*TST* 114). I'll explore how these sacrifices are made, why they are made, and for what reason, and ultimately I'll try to determine what result these self-sacrifices have in changing or altering the pattern.

In *The Wandering Fire* (hereafter *TWF*), Finn dan Shahar gives up his mortal life to join the Wild Hunt but ultimately dies in the third volume, *The Darkest Road* (hereafter *TDR*) trying to deter the Hunt from its destructive course (*TWF* 352; *TDR* 743). Kevin Laine sacrifices himself in a highly ritualized manner in order to end the unnatural winter (*TWF* 394-99), and Matt Sören sacrifices all of his energy and therefore his life to fuel Loren the mage's magic so he can defeat a traitor (*TWF* 463). I will analyze the differences and similarities between these sacrifices in my second chapter and note their relative importance. I'll further explore how these sacrifices alter the pattern of the world or at least how they change the lives of the people around them.

Finally, in my third chapter, I will explore the willing self-sacrifices made in *TDR*. Two of these are the most significant examples in the whole trilogy of how the pattern

can be altered through willing self-sacrifice and what that alteration means in a broader sense. The first example is when Prince Diarmuid dan Ailell takes King Arthur's place in a battle that he was fated to participate in, so altering his doom (*TDR* 702-09). The second is when Darien sacrifices himself to kill the evil god Rakoth Maugrim and save the world (*TDR* 736). Through careful examination, I hope to show that Kay emphasizes not only that there is a high cost to victory but also that through willing self-sacrifice destiny can be changed. In fact, there is no possible way the Tapestry can be successfully completed without willing self-sacrifice. It is this emphasis on free will through the medium of self-sacrifice that sets Kay apart from Tolkien: there may be a grand plan in place for human beings but we have the power to change that plan through our choices.

CHAPTER ONE: An Analysis of *The Summer Tree*

In this chapter, I will discuss *The Summer Tree*, the first volume of *The Fionavar Tapestry*. Specifically, I am going to address two important instances of willing self-sacrifice in this volume. Paul Schafer, a Canadian university student, and Ysanne, the Seer of Brennin, are the characters who most notably sacrifice themselves. I will explore the nature and motives of each of these characters in order to illuminate the sacrifices they both make and why they were driven to make them.

TST begins with an “Overture,” or what in most novels would be called a Prologue. Kay calls it an overture because of the musical structure of the novel itself: it is constructed like an opera with four acts. In the space of a page and a half, Kay sketches his secondary world, Fionavar, offering details of its history which will be important later in the trilogy. We are introduced to the greatest force of evil in the secondary world, Rakoth Maugrim, and learn that he was bound and imprisoned under a mountain after a war (13). We are also informed that Maugrim is “outside of time, outside of death” (14) and is prepared to wait for centuries to break free from his prison. Five “wardstones,” magical artifacts that glow blue to indicate that Maugrim is still trapped and will turn red if he attempts to escape, were created to guard against that possibility and distributed to different peoples throughout Fionavar. Though much else changed in Fionavar over time, the rituals of the wardstones, such as keeping a special fire burning with them, were constantly observed and Maugrim was unable to break free. However, the last sentences of the Overture very strongly foreshadow Maugrim’s eventual escape: “And a thousand years passed under the sun and stars of the first of all the worlds” (14). When

the main narrative begins, there have been a thousand years of relative peace but this is all about to change.

The Overture is important for a number of reasons. The first is that it establishes a clear timeline for the secondary world which in turn orders that world and helps make it more plausible. In *The Fellowship of the Ring* (1954), the first volume of *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy, J.R.R Tolkien spends nearly the first half of the novel establishing a history for his world so that it may seem more credible to the reader who is entering it for the first time. His hobbits travel through the Old Forest and the Barrow-Downs, two locations indicative of entities that have either been around for a long time or ancient civilizations that have now been nearly forgotten.

Kay weaves history into the rest of his narrative as well but begins with the context that readers must be aware of in order to understand what will happen. This method closely mirrors Tolkien's, though Tolkien imparts similar information at the beginning of his trilogy in a poem rather than a short prologue: "Three Rings for the Elven-kings under the sky,/Seven for the dwarf-lords in their halls of stone,/Nine for Mortal Men doomed to die,/One for the Dark Lord on his dark throne/In the land of Mordor where the Shadows lie" (Tolkien, *Fellowship*). Tolkien also includes a Prologue, in which he explains hobbits, but his is structured less like a story and more like a series of facts about a particular race. The similarities and differences become quite clear when we compare Tolkien's verse to the first few sentences of Kay's Overture:

After the war was over, they bound him under the Mountain. And so that there might be warning if he moved to escape, they crafted then, with magic and with art, the five wardstones, last creation and the finest of Ginserat. One went south

across Saeren to Cathal, one over the mountains to Eridu, another remained with Revor and the Dalrei on the Plain. The fourth wardstone Colan carried home, Conary's son, now High King in Paras Derval.

The last stone was accepted, though in bitterness of heart, by the broken remnant of the lios alfar. (*TST* 13)

In both texts, powerful and magical items that are distributed between various different peoples or races become crucial to their respective narratives and help establish a history. One of the differences, however, is that Kay imparts this information to the reader through prose and Tolkien does so through verse. While there are some songs of importance in Kay's trilogy, he does not include nearly as many poems or lyrics in his novels as Tolkien does. This choice to not include as many songs can be seen as one of Kay's efforts to move away from the Tolkienian tradition and demonstrate that fantasy can be written differently. Both methods are efficient at communicating back story but Kay's use of prose rather than poetry and of legends rather than songs give his world a more modern quality. In a sense, he elevates his prose to the same level as Tolkien's poetry to prove that prose can be just as artful as verse. Furthermore, the structure of *TST* mirrors the structure of an opera, as mentioned, and emphasizes the importance of music. "Rachel's Song" is the second and most important part of the novel and Rachel Kincaid dedicates the second movement of the Brahms F Major Cello Sonata to Paul to represent her love for him. By reflecting an opera and its acts rather than a poem in the larger form of his novel, Kay also differentiates himself from Tolkien while still paying homage to him.

After the Overture, the narrative is divided into four parts. The first of these is the shortest: it contains only three chapters and is entitled “Silvercloak.” This part opens not in the secondary world of Fionavar but in contemporary Toronto where the reader is introduced to five Canadians, Kimberly Ford, Paul Schafer, Kevin Laine, Jennifer Lowell, and Dave Martyniuk, who will become the protagonists of the trilogy. The only two characters actually from Fionavar who are introduced in this part are Loren Silvercloak, a mage, and Matt Sören, a dwarf magically bound to Loren so that his life force can serve as the source of Loren’s magic. The terms *dwarf* and *mage* are medieval terms from a long tradition that Tolkien draws from. Kay purposefully uses them as well, but Loren Silvercloak is not Gandalf and Matt Sören is certainly not Gimli. The bond between them is evidence of that: Gandalf, as a magical being, does not need to use another as the source for his magic, whereas Loren does. Matt is revealed to be the King of the dwarves and while Matt is certainly capable of fighting, Gimli is much more of a warrior than Matt. Again, Kay takes these terms made familiar by Tolkien and changes or adapts them.

These first three chapters begin to establish the personal histories and personalities of the five Canadians as well as some special character traits that will become important later. For example, when Loren tries to perform a “searching” on Paul, namely, a way of reading someone magically, Paul has confusing visions that foreshadow his sacrifice on the Summer Tree. Similarly, at the beginning of the third chapter, on the morning when the five are to leave for Fionavar, Kimberly has a dream of “a place of jumbled stones” (32) where she knows she has come to summon someone. This dream becomes realised

in the second book of the trilogy, *The Wandering Fire*, for dreams are as closely linked to Kim's character arc as the Summer Tree is to Paul's.

These five Canadians, all students at the University of Toronto, attend a conference where the "reclusive genius" (18) Lorenzo Marcus is giving a lecture and chairing a panel. Lorenzo is actually Loren Silvercloak who has come to our world to bring five people back to Fionavar with him in celebration of Ailell's fiftieth year as High King of Brennin, one of several kingdoms in Fionavar. At the end of the third chapter, the Canadians are transported to Fionavar itself where most of the action of the trilogy unfolds.

Part two of *TST*, "Rachel's Song", comprising six chapters, is the longest section of this volume and arguably the most important. It is also the part that I will be paying most attention to here as it features the two sacrifices I am focusing on. During their "crossing," namely, their magical transition to Fionavar, Dave refuses to hold onto the others in the circle so he does not come to Brennin with the other four but is instead transported to a different part of Fionavar. His narrative thread is not picked up again until the third part of the volume, "The Children of Ivor." The other four Canadians do arrive in Brennin and remain for the King's celebration. King Ailell is not introduced until chapter five, but his son, Prince Diarmuid dan Ailell, is one of the first characters Kim, Paul, Jennifer and Kevin meet after their crossing, which indicates his importance to the narrative overall. The four discover that there has been a terrible drought in Brennin and that the land is dying. This information becomes particularly important to Kim and Paul: to Kim, because she can feel the pain of the land which is indicative of

her close connection to Fionavar and her eventual fate as the Seer of Brennin; and to Paul because his sacrifice on the Summer Tree will end the drought.

Initiated by Dave's disappearance, it is this part of *TST* in which the four characters from our world are divided from each other and begin their various separate journeys. Kim leaves Paras Derval, the capital of Brennin, after the celebration for King Ailell to visit Ysanne at her cabin near a lake. Here, Ysanne teaches Kim what it is like to be a Dreamer and the Seer of Brennin. Kim receives an explanation about what that actually means through visions of the World Tapestry. She is given the magical ring called the Baelrath that will become a source of her eventual power and Ysanne makes the sacrifice that completes Kim's understanding of Fionavar.

Paul and Kevin leave with Diarmuid and his men for Cathal so Diarmuid can seduce Princess Sharra. Jennifer is left behind and explores more of her surroundings, bearing witness to what appears to be a child's game called the ta'kiena (90-2) where the girl Laila is blindfolded in the middle of a circle of other children and spins while singing a song that, unbeknownst to her, is actually a prophecy. Laila chooses Finn for the darkest road at the end of this game, the third time Finn has been chosen. After a conversation with Matt, Jennifer is restless and rides away from the city where she encounters a group of the lios alfar, Kay's version of Tolkien's elves, who invite her to the woods with them. There, she is kidnapped by Galadan, the wolf lord, and Avaia, the Black Swan, and taken to Starkadh, the fortress of Rakoth Maugrim. Jennifer's imprisonment there results in the birth of Darien, a character of crucial importance to my study of self-sacrifice in the trilogy and whom I will discuss in detail in Chapter Three.

Paul and Kevin return from their successful escapade with Diarmuid and go to a tavern where Paul goes upstairs with a woman. However, he leaves when she begins crying because he is unable to take pleasure from their intimacy. Kevin, alerted of Paul's disappearance, goes looking for him but is prompted to sing a song for Diarmuid and his men since they have brought Kevin's guitar from the palace. Kevin sings the song he wrote for Rachel Kincaid, Paul's girlfriend, who died in a car crash when Paul was driving the previous summer. Paul hears the song from outside the tavern which prompts him to go to the king and offer himself up as Ailell's replacement sacrifice, go on the Summer Tree, and end the drought. While Paul is on the Tree, Rangat Cloud-Shouldered, the mountain beneath which Rakoth Maugrim is bound, explodes, signalling to the world that Rakoth Maugrim is once again free. The shock kills King Ailell and prompts Aileron, Diarmuid's elder brother who had been banished for treason, to come out of hiding and return to take his rightful place as High King of Brenninn and lead the war against Maugrim.

The third part of *TST*, "The Children of Ivor," is four chapters long and details what has happened to Dave while everything else is going on. As with all separations in the trilogy, Dave's allows Kay to introduce us to another aspect of his world. After his crossing, Dave lands on the Plain, the area to the north of Brenninn, and befriends the Dalrei, the people of the plains, particularly Torc and Levon. He learns about their culture and how to be a warrior. Levon's younger brother Tabor goes on a spirit quest while Dave is still with the tribe and meets Imraith-Nimphais, his spirit animal, a unicorn born in Pendaran Wood under the blood moon. After about a week, Dave starts on his way back to Brenninn, accompanied by Torc and Levon. On the way, they are attacked by

wolves and forced to take shelter in Pendaran Wood, where the trees, though not quite as mobile as Tolkien's Ents, seem to be alive and do not take kindly to intruders. Ceinwen, a huntress goddess similar to the Greek Artemis, leaves Dave with Owein's horn and he, Levon, and Torc discover the place where the Wild Hunt, a company of ghostly kings and an embodiment of chaos, is imprisoned.

The last part, "The Unraveller," is only two chapters long and details the rape and torture of Jennifer by Rakoth Maugrim at Starkadh and how Aileron becomes High King. Maugrim attempts to break Jennifer's mind during this sequence and impregnates her, but plans to have her killed so the child will never be born. Maugrim's plans to kill her are foiled because Jennifer is rescued as Kim transports herself and the other four Canadians back to our world. Jennifer is deeply changed by this traumatic event and becomes quite cold, blocking off her feelings from the rest of the world.

I will now discuss in detail the significance of the willing self-sacrifices of Ysanne and Paul. As with many of the sacrifices in the trilogy, both of these actions are paradoxically at once fated but freely chosen. This paradox is the same in Tolkien: Frodo volunteers to take the Ring to Mordor but his volunteering, though and action freely chosen, was also fated. Kay explores the relation between fate and free will, a common theme in the fantasy genre. Throughout *Fionavar* protagonists may be strongly impelled to make certain choices, but they still have the freedom to choose not to act.

Ysanne's and Paul's sacrifices are freely chosen and both have an element of ritual about them. The first of these sacrifices that is completed chronologically is that of Ysanne the Seer. She is introduced during the celebration of Ailell's kingship (50-4). Diarmuid interrupts an argument to point out that they have another guest: "Stepping

lightly from the dais, [Diarmuid] walked past all of them, down to the end of the hall, where Kim saw as she turned to watch, there stood another woman, this one white-haired with age and leaning on a gnarled staff before the great doors of Ailell's hall" (53). The events are related from Kim's point of view because she and Ysanne, due to their prophetic dreams and position as Seers, are profoundly connected even if Kim does not yet realise this. Ysanne declares that she is a Seer soon after she meets Kim's gaze and beckons Kim to come to her, though "only Kim herself had seen the spasm of fear that had crossed Ysanne's face" (54). The fear indicates Ysanne's knowledge of her coming death; seeing Kim in person confirms for Ysanne what she once dreamed – that Kim would become her successor – and foreshadows her own sacrifice.

The close connection between Kim and Ysanne is established when Kim, first hearing Ysanne's name, "felt something touch her then, like a finger on the heart" (53). White-haired Ysanne is the "dreamer of the dream," she who possesses magic that allows her to glimpse the pattern of the World Tapestry and therefore have precognitive dreams of the future. She foreshadows Kim's own destiny as a dreamer and the future Seer of Brennin. Ysanne is, in quite a literal way, Kim's future, or at least one facet of her future. Ysanne sacrifices her place in the World Tapestry, essentially her afterlife, by killing herself and merging her soul with Kim's. It is because of this merging that Ysanne will not be able to continue into her afterlife. Ysanne's self-sacrifice gives Kim what is necessary to help Fionavar.

Ysanne the Seer dreamt long ago of the important role that Kim would play in Fionavar. Ysanne's dream not only told her that Kim would become her successor but also gave Ysanne the knowledge she would need to enable this event. Ysanne knows that

it is Kim who will be needed in the coming war with Maugrim and the forces of evil because she dreamt the Baelrath, the ring that is also called the Warstone, on Kim's finger. Dreaming and premonitions are common tropes in fantasy narratives because the world of dreams is associated with magic and prophecy. In *The Fellowship of the Ring*, before Frodo and the other hobbits set off into the Old Forest, Frodo has a confused dream that is in some ways prophetic not only about the forest but also "the sound of the Sea far-off; a sound he had never heard in waking life, though it had often troubled his dreams" (Tolkien, *Fellowship* 142). At the end of Tolkien's trilogy, Frodo leaves the world he knows and goes across the sea with Bilbo and the elves. His dream is clearly tied to his future but in a less specific way than Ysanne's dreams of her future.

Kay deploys the existing trope of the prophetic dream but, as with many facets of his trilogy, changes it to emphasize the importance of willing self-sacrifice. Ysanne's dream of Kim's eventual journey to Fionavar inscribes the event firmly within the Tapestry. Clearly, this is an event that was fated to happen. Some might say Ysanne herself dreamed it into being, but Kay's implication seems to be that prophetic dreamers are afforded a glimpse of what is to come, not that they create that future themselves. Ysanne's dream of her own demise could also be fated but there is no outside force compelling her to take her own soul and give it to Kim aside from the fact that she dreamed it. It is not clear what force, if any, caused her to dream about her death. Being a Seer and having the ability to dream prophetically firmly links Ysanne to Fionavar but there is no threat to Ysanne if she does not sacrifice herself. This is not to say that there is an example of someone being threatened if they do not make a sacrifice but I draw attention to this incident to emphasize the importance of her choice. Her self-sacrifice

becomes a choice she makes freely even if she is influenced by her belief that she must do it in order for Fionavar to survive.

I mentioned above that there was a ritual element to Ysanne's willing self-sacrifice. Her actions in relation to Kim immediately before she sacrifices herself make this ritual element evident:

Ysanne's fingers, still beautiful, traced a sign lightly and irrevocably on the unfurrowed brow. Kimberly slept.... 'Sleep, child,' [Ysanne] murmured. 'You have need, for the way is dark and there will be fire ere the end, and a breaking of the heart. Grieve not in the morning for my soul; my dream is done, my dreaming. May the Weaver name you his, and shield you from the Dark all your days' (*TST* 133).

Ysanne is mortal, but since she is also the Seer the gift she makes of her soul to Kim is even more significant. The sign Ysanne traces on Kim's forehead is what will ultimately make Ysanne's soul join with Kim's when the old Seer kills herself with the dagger Lökdal. This is a magical dagger whose powers are described thus:

Who kills without love shall surely die, Seithr the Dwarf-King had said to Colan the Beloved long ago. And then, lowering his voice, he had added for only the son of Conary to hear, "Who dies with love may make of his soul a gift to the one marked with the pattern on the dagger's haft."

"A rich gift," had murmured Colan.

"Richer than you know. Once given, the soul is gone. It is lost to time. There can be no passage beyond the walls of Night to find light at the Weaver's side."
(138)

There is clearly a ritual associated with the use of the dagger. The tracing of a sigil and the blessing Ysanne gives Kim, like the blessing given to an animal before taking its life in sacrifice, emphasize the ritualistic nature of this self-sacrifice. Compare the Hindu ritual of animal sacrifice: “[a]fter it has been bathed, it is brought in, whilst various libations are made. It is then addressed, laudatory epithets being heaped upon it, and it is exhorted to keep calm” (Hubert and Mauss 30). It is possible that Kay was influenced by Hindu beliefs but more likely that he was more inspired by ancient Greek or Celtic druidic sacrifices. It is interesting, however, to note that though Kim is the one receiving the blessing, she is not the one being sacrificed. Instead, Ysanne essentially offers her own soul, not to a deity, but to Kim herself, so that Kim and Fionavar, not Ysanne, can benefit from this sacrifice. Ysanne believes her sacrifice to be worth it because she knows from her dream that Kim needs to understand the Pattern of the Tapestry if she is to take over as the Seer of Brennin. Possessing Ysanne’s soul will tie Kim more firmly to Fionavar and allow her to access the power she will require to fulfill her destiny.

In *Sacrifice Imagined* (2011), Douglas Hedley discusses various types of sacrifice. One of the types is not rooted in religious practice: “Sacrifice is understood instead as exchange. Here the idea is that sacrifice is really a mode of reciprocity.... I give so that you give to me ... can be seen as the core of sacrifice” (62). Ysanne’s self-sacrifice functions something like this, though she does not directly benefit from the exchange so it is not exactly reciprocity. She hopes, instead, that Fionavar will benefit from Kim’s power. Ysanne kills herself with Lökdaal thereby transferring her soul to Kim. Thereupon Kim receives the knowledge and connection to Fionavar she requires so she can benefit Fionavar at large as the new Seer. Ysanne knew Kim would come and that such an

action would be necessary in order for good to triumph in the coming battle against evil. It is particularly important that good triumphs in Fionavar because it is “the prime creation, which all the [other worlds] imperfectly reflect” (*TST* 24), as Loren explains. If evil were to triumph in Fionavar, the effect would ripple through all the other worlds and doom them.

Paul Schafer is another important figure in the battle against Maugrim and his forces of evil. In order to gain his unusual powers, however, he must sacrifice himself on the Summer Tree. While Ysanne’s self-sacrifice was rooted in ritual and not mythology, Paul’s is deeply connected to both Norse and Christian mythology. In the Norse myths, Odin hung on the world tree, Yggdrasil, for nine days in order to gain knowledge and wisdom. Odin’s sacrifice is also uniquely paradoxical because Odin sacrifices himself to himself (Crossley-Holland 15). No one really knows what this means and it complicates the notion of the sacrifice itself. Odin performs the sacrifice to gain knowledge, but also offers himself as a sacrifice to himself. In this way, Odin’s sacrifice is both a ‘sacrifice to’ and a ‘sacrifice for’ in Moshe Halbertal’s terms, just as Paul’s is. In Christian mythology, Jesus hung on the cross for three days and was then resurrected to redeem mankind from original sin. There are elements of both of these events in Paul’s sacrifice. The time frame and the rebirth motif are more reflective of Jesus’ sacrifice but the events that occur in the grove of the Summer Tree and the gods that appear are much closer to Norse myth. Kay draws from mythologies that predate Christianity but since Fionavar is the first of all worlds and the others simply reflections of it, there is inevitably an overlap between pagan and Christian myth in its beliefs and practices. Christian beliefs were influenced by earlier pagan beliefs and Kay takes advantage of this fact by melding the

two in Fionavar. As mentioned above, Paul's is the first sacrifice in the trilogy that combines Moshe Halbertal's notions of 'sacrificing to' and 'sacrificing for.' Paul becomes both an offering to Mörnir, so a sacrifice to a deity, but his is also a sacrifice for, as he chooses to give up his own life for the wellbeing of others.

Paul is somewhat different from the other Canadians right from the beginning of the novel. He is the only one who realises Loren is performing a "searching" on him, and this searching inspires visions that prefigure his fate on the Summer Tree:

The light and sound in the room faded completely. He felt a great darkness. There was a forest, a corridor of whispering trees, shrouded in mist. Starlight in the space above the trees. Somehow he knew that the moon was about to rise, and when it rose ... [t]he immersion was complete, and within some hidden recess Paul confronted the terrible, haunted eyes of a dog or a wolf. Then the vision fragmented, images whipping past, chaotic, myriad, too fast to hold, except for one: a tall man standing in darkness, and upon his head the great, curved antlers of a stag. (19)

There is a corridor of trees that lead up to the Summer Tree itself; Galadan and Cavall, wolf and dog respectively, do battle in front of Paul while he hangs on the Tree; and Cernan (from Cernunnos, the Welsh Horned God) the God of Beasts, is the antlered figure who bows to Paul near the end of his time on the Tree. While not exactly a clear premonition, this fragmented vision demonstrates that Paul is more susceptible to magical influence than the other four Canadians.

Furthermore, Paul is ill when they travel to Fionavar. He is emotionally and spiritually closed off and has been this way since Rachel Kincaid's death. Kevin, Paul's

closest friend, worries even before Paul goes to the Tree that he may not care about his own well-being when the two of them are climbing down a cliff face to help Diarmuid seduce Princess Sharra: “Paul, Kevin thought wearily, that’ll be Paul. And then another thought invaded him and registered hard over exhaustion: *he doesn’t care if he falls*. The realization hit with the force of apprehended truth” (70; emphasis in original). Kevin goes on to remember how two weeks ago he’d had to take Paul to the hospital after a basketball game (71). Paul is clearly in crisis before he comes to Fionavar, physically weakened and emotionally cold because of the death of his girlfriend for which he unjustly blames himself. These qualities both become important when Paul decides to offer himself to the Tree.

The Tree itself is mentioned several times before Paul actually approaches it and we are given a full, physical description. It is first mentioned by King Ailell after he and Paul have played chess in his rooms and the lios alfar, Na-Brendel, has come to visit. Ailell admits: “‘And truly, I do not want to die, on the Tree or otherwise. If this is my failing, then so it must be’” (61). Paul, not knowing what the Tree is, asks Diarmuid’s lieutenant Coll about it when he is being escorted back to his rooms:

“The Summer Tree?” [Coll] said. “It’s in the wood west of the town. Sacred it is, to Mörnir of the Thunder.”

“Why is it important?”

“Because,” said Coll, lower yet, “that’s where the God would summon the High King in the old days, when the land had need.”

“Summon him for what?”

“To hang on the Summer Tree and die,” said Coll succinctly. (62)

When Matt is taking Kim to Ysanne a little later, he notes, “‘I begin to wonder about the old tale of Mörnir’s Tree, and the pact the founder made with the God’” (67). This adds slightly more detail than Coll’s explanation about the history of the Tree. Clearly, a deal was made when the High Kingdom of Brennín was founded that promised the high kings or princes of royal blood to Mörnir and the Tree if the land was in need. The Tree becomes, then, a place of ritual sacrifice associated with Brennín’s royal line.

The ritual of the Tree is made clearer when Paul finally offers himself as the sacrifice in Ailell’s place, something Diarmuid’s older brother Aileron, the exiled prince, had done before him. The king refused and since Aileron insisted, he was accused of treason and exiled. Ailell accepts Paul’s offering, however: “‘I will go to the Summer Tree for you tonight. Will you grant me leave and do what must be done?’ It seemed to have been written a very long time ago. There was music. Ailell was weeping as he spoke, but he said what was needful to be said.... The music still was with [Paul] and the last words of Ailell: *Now I give you to Mörnir. For three nights and forever*” (114; emphasis in original). Finally, when Paul approaches the Tree we are given a physical description:

Very great it was, dark almost to black, its trunk knotted and gnarled, wide as a house. It stood alone in the clearing, in the place of sacrifice, and clutched the earth with roots old as the world, a challenge to the stars that shone down, and there was power in that place beyond the telling. (114-5)

We can compare this Tree to Yggdrasil, the World Tree of Norse Myth: “The axis of the world was Yggdrasil. That ash soared and its branches fanned over gods and men and giants and dwarfs. It sheltered all creation” (Crossley-Holland 15). As the Summer Tree and the Norse World Tree are linked, so Paul is linked to Odin who is represented by

Mörnir in Fionavar. After his rebirth on the Tree, Paul becomes the Arrow of Mörnir, a weapon of the god, and he has two ravens that sometimes accompany him like Odin's ravens, Thought and Memory.

Dena Taylor points out that "Paul becomes, on the level of archetypal reality, the Hanged God." This motif is derived from J.G. Frazer's comparative anthropological studies of ancient forms of worship. Representatives of the god Attis, and of many other gods, were "regularly hanged or otherwise slain upon the sacred tree" (Frazer, *Adonis* 289). Frazer also points out how the human sacrifices made to Odin "were regularly put to death by hanging or by a combination of hanging and stabbing.... Hence Odin was called the Lord of the Gallows or the God of the Hanged" (290). Finally, Frazer states that "we can hardly dismiss as wholly improbable the conjecture that in Phrygia a man-god may have hung year by year on the sacred but fatal tree" (292-3). Frazer uses the term "man-god" because the person being sacrificed was mortal but supposed to embody the God. Paul's situation is similar: Mörnir is the Odin of Fionavar so the ritual of hanging his sacrifice on a sacred tree makes sense.

Christ was both human and divine so the term "man-god" also relates to Him. Paul never was and never will be an actual god, but he was always set apart from the other Canadians. Paul's otherness, in accordance with Girard's theory of sacrifice, makes him an ideal candidate for it. After his sacrifice and rebirth, Paul's path is a lonely one because the supernatural powers he has been given grant him knowledge and abilities that are not always fully under his control. In his MA thesis entitled "Custodial Heroes, Moral Soldiers, and Willing Sacrifices: Heroic Masculinity in Modern Epic Fantasy" (2009), Sean David McKenzie points out that in Kay's work some characters "are able to

return from their sacrifice, or be fulfilled through it and ‘return’ in less than literal ways, but they are no longer a part of the human world in Fionavar, though they must still live within it” (McKenzie 111-2). This statement is certainly true of Paul, though he is one of only two characters who are able to return from a sacrifice of this nature.

Paul’s is at once a willing sacrifice and an offering to a god. He becomes a potential saviour to the people, for if he survives the three nights on the Tree it will end the drought and save the land. Saving the land is only part of Paul’s motivation for going on the Tree, however. He blames himself for the death of his girlfriend, Rachel, because he was the one driving the car when they had the accident that killed her. Though it was raining that night, Rachel had just confessed to Paul that she had been unfaithful to him and had agreed to marry the other man. Paul believes he did not act fast enough to avoid the collision that killed her. McKenzie argues that “[i]t is important to realize that characters may choose to sacrifice themselves based on purely selfish motives, even if that sacrifice saves others” (112). A few pages later, McKenzie states: “[Paul’s] sacrifice is prompted by this self-doubt and disgust, which causes him to believe that he deserves the painful death he undertakes” (117). This statement is certainly true: Paul indeed believes that he deserves a painful death because of his guilt over Rachel’s death. He sees his sacrifice partially as an atonement which could be a new type of sacrifice. Paul wrongly believes that he is responsible for Rachel’s death, however, so he does not actually need to atone for it. However, that does not mean his motivation for performing the sacrifice is purely self-centred. If Paul were truly suicidal, there are many other ways he could have chosen to end his own life. He could have allowed himself to fall when climbing down the rock face with Diarmuid and his men, for example, but he does not.

Instead, Paul chooses a fate, deserved or not, that will have a positive impact on Fioanvar. If his motivations were purely selfish there would have been no reason for him to go on the Tree in the first place. Paul reflects on this when he is listening to Ailell say the words that go with the ritual: “Because it was one thing to die, and another to die uselessly” (*TST* 114).

Like Christ, Paul spends three full nights on the Tree and Kay breaks up the narrative of that time into five separate parts. Paul’s binding to the Tree is clearly part of the ritual of the sacrifice because Gorlaes, the King’s Chancellor, and two men “stripped [Paul] of his garments then and bound him naked to the Summer Tree at the waning of the moon.... Alone upon the Tree, he felt within his flesh the incalculable vastness of its power, and had there been anything left to fear, he would have been afraid” (115). The other parts detail Paul’s suffering on the Tree and are interspersed with flashbacks to his relationship with Rachel and the night of the car accident.

During the second part, it becomes obvious that Paul is not just making this sacrifice for selfish reasons: “[H]e was a gift, an offering, and it was all a waste if he died too soon. So he had to hold to life, hold the wall, hold for the God, for he was the God’s to claim, and there was thunder now” (128). Not long after Paul has made this decision to continue struggling and fighting, Galadan, a demi-god who can take the form of a wolf (cf. the Fenris wolf of Norse myth) and who is a servant of Rakoth Maugrim, comes to the glade to kill Paul and prevent the sacrifice. Paul closes his eyes, seemingly ready to accept his death – indeed, there is little he can do to prevent it. The killing stroke never comes, however, because Galadan is interrupted by the arrival of a grey dog that we later learn is Cavall, the Companion, King Arthur’s dog in the Welsh tradition.

A legendary battle takes place between Galadan and Cavall:

There took place then a battle foretold in the first depths of time by the twin goddesses of war, who are named in all the worlds as Macha and Nemain. A portent it was to be, a presaging of the greatest war of all, this coming together in darkness of the wolf, who was a man whose spirit was annihilation, and the grey dog, who had been called by many names but was always the Companion.

The battle the two goddesses foreknew – for war was their demesne – but not the resolution. A portent then, a presaging, a beginning. (129)

Cavall's guarding of Paul is what brings this battle about, though clearly it had been long foretold. The battle continues through the night with Paul looking on and when the dog begins to lose, Paul makes it a promise: “‘*Fight!*’ [Paul] screamed suddenly, his throat raw with effort. ‘Go on! I’ll hold if you can – I’ll make it through tomorrow night. In the name of the God, I swear it. Give me till tomorrow night and I’ll bring you rain’” (130). While Paul had been prepared to die when Galadan was going to kill him, the strength and bravery shown by the dog invigorate him and give him the will to fight. The promise works and the dog rallies, eventually beating Galadan back and forcing him to retreat.

The significance of this battle is twofold. First, since the battle was long foretold by the war goddesses and was a sign of the war to come, when Cavall, the force of good in the battle wins, it foreshadows the triumph of good over evil in the coming war. Second, and more important here, the battle gives Paul some of the strength he needs to stay alive on the Tree. It also results in Paul gaining some of the power he will have once he comes off the Tree. After the battle, Cavall approaches Paul: “For the second time their eyes met, and this time Paul did not back away. He took in the loss he saw, all of it, the pain

endured for him and endured long before him, and with the first power of the Tree, he made it his own” (131). Paul claims the pain the dog has endured and takes it into himself. When Paul comes off the Tree, because of his empathy for the dog and its pain, he has a deeper understanding of the secondary world. The way he lays claim to that history of pain is akin to how his body becomes representative of the land scoured by drought. His death, then, is supposed to heal that land.

The third part takes place only hours after the battle during the second night and is not even a page long. Paul is in a great deal of pain at this point but struggles to hold to the oath he made to the dog. He believes he is hallucinating when he receives another visitor: “This man had a beard, and deep-set dark eyes, and didn’t seem about to change into an animal.... And what [Paul] saw on the face of the figure below was an expression of such appalling, balked desire that the hair rose up on his neck.... ‘You have stolen my death,’ the figure said” (134). Though Paul is too delirious to realise it, this figure is Aileron, the eldest son of King Ailell, who offered to go on the Tree for his father and was refused. Aileron’s bitterness is understandable: he was exiled for offering to do the very thing that Paul is doing. It becomes clear later that Aileron could not have been the one to make the sacrifice on the Tree because he is needed to lead Brennín’s army in the coming war. Aileron thinks Paul has stolen his death, but it was never Aileron’s destiny to die on the Tree. By making the choice to go on the Tree, Paul ensures Aileron’s rightful place in the Pattern. Paul’s choice and his willing sacrifice are necessary for the Pattern to be fully completed. This seems somewhat contrary to what I mentioned in my Introduction when I stated that willing self-sacrifice alters the Pattern. In Chapter Three,

I will discuss two specific sacrifices that differ from Paul's and drastically alter the Pattern of the World Tapestry.

The fourth part is the longest and takes place during the second day and third night when Paul, in his delirium, is taken back to his relationship with Rachel on the night she died. Right at the beginning of this section we are told: "He was badly sunburned now, and so dry. Dry as the land, which, he had thought earlier – how much earlier? – was probably the point. The nexus" (149). Throughout the earlier sections, Paul slowly started to feel as though he was part of the Tree itself which, while he still lives, grants him his unusual powers. Paul's body reflects the state of the dry, dead land. Being physically naked and dry on the Tree is not enough, however, because for the sacrifice to work the victim has to be stripped of all protection not only physically but also spiritually and face his greatest fear: "And he understood then, finally: understood that it had to be naked, truly so, that one went to the God. It was the Tree that was stripping him, layer by layer, down to what he was hiding from" (151). For Paul, that is the night Rachel died and his guilt about thinking he purposely did not act fast enough in spite of the rain on the highway and the other cars careening out of control around him.

The most important part of this section is Paul's choice not to die, and it is a choice he makes freely. While he has already chosen to go on the Tree and offer himself as sacrifice, he is still able to let go if he wishes. He can choose not to face that night again but die instead, and though his death would not bring rain to Brenninn, it would at least free him from his torment. Paul chooses, however, to face what he wants to avoid. If his only motive for going on the Tree were to kill himself then he would have chosen to let go, to die before the ritual had been fully completed. He does not and that is why his

willing self-sacrifice is so important. He faces what no other could and truly sacrifices everything in order to save the land from the drought:

He was the Arrow now. The Arrow on the Tree, of Mörnir, and he was to be given naked or not at all.

Or not at all. There was that, he realized. He could die. That was still his choice, he could let go. It was there for him.

And so on the third night Paul Schafer came to the last test, the one that was always failed, the opening. Where the Kings of Brennin, or those coming in their name, discovered that the courage to be there, the strength to endure, even love of their land were none of them enough. On the Tree one could no longer hide from the living or the dead, from one's own soul. Naked or not at all, one went to Mörnir.... And so they would let go, brave Kings of the sword, wise ones, gallant Princes, all would turn away from so much nakedness and die too soon.

But not that night. Because of pride, of pure stubbornness, and because, most surely, of the dog, Paul Schafer found the courage not to turn. Down he went.

Arrow of the God. So open, the wind could pass, light shine through him. (151)

Dena Taylor relates Paul to the Fisher-King: "Paul is substituting for the High King Ailell, whose age and ill-health are mirrored in the drought destroying the land." Paul finds the strength to persevere and completely bare his soul in order to fulfill the demands of the sacrifice. He may owe some of that strength to the dog who fought to protect him but it is really Paul's choice to go through with it that sets him apart. Because of that choice, the Mother Goddess Dana comes to him and shows him that it was not his fault that Rachel died, that he failed to drive the car into safety on the night

of the accident because he was only human. This is similar to Tolkien's notion of grace; it is an unexpected, joyous turn where spirits are suddenly lifted. Paul is forgiven for Rachel's death and, upon seeing the truth of the matter, he cries for Rachel which he has not allowed himself to do. It is this action, finally, that completes the ritual and brings the rain because, when Paul as representative of the land finally allows himself to cry, the rain is allowed to fall.

The fifth part involves the meeting of Dana and Mörnir in the wood after Paul has completed the sacrifice. Dana asks Mörnir to intercede, as she has done with the blood moon and the birth of the unicorn Imraith-Nimphais in Pendaran Wood, and allow Paul to live. This request is granted and Paul's time on the Tree ends. Even though he did not experience literal death, he certainly experienced figurative death. Paul's willing sacrifice to save the land and himself, and Ysanne's sacrifice of her soul and afterlife for Kim are necessary acts without which the Pattern of the World Tapestry cannot be satisfactorily completed. Paul's theft of Aileron's death and Ysanne's gift to Kim allow both Aileron and Kim to fulfill their true destinies and are therefore an integral part of the Pattern. Both Paul, who performed an act of self-sacrifice, and Kim, the beneficiary of one such sacrifice, through these acts are changed in ways that make them essential to the trilogy's positive outcome. Every self-sacrifice, as I will continue to demonstrate in the following chapters, is essential not only to the victory of good over evil but also to the satisfactory completion of the World Tapestry.

CHAPTER TWO: An Analysis of *The Wandering Fire*

The focus of this chapter is *The Wandering Fire*, the second volume of *Fionavar*. The discussion here will be specifically concerned with instances of willing self-sacrifice that move the narrative forward and demonstrate the importance of such actions to the successful completion of the World Tapestry in *Fionavar*. There are three notable self-sacrifices in this volume: Finn, a boy of about fourteen, gives up his mortal life to become a spirit figure and join the Wild Hunt; Kevin Laine enacts an old ritual to end the unnatural winter; and Matt Sören, source to the mage Loren Silvercloak and once King of the Dwarves, gives his life to end the tyranny and destruction of a treacherous mage. I will analyse the nature and motivations of these characters and explore the greater context of their sacrifices.

Unlike *TST*, *TWF* does not begin with an Overture or a prologue of any kind. It is, however, divided into four parts like the previous volume. The lack of a prologue is likely due to the fact that it is the second volume in a trilogy and all the relevant backstory concerning the secondary world has already been established in the previous volume. I should note here that my summary pays some attention to Darien, whose crucial sacrifice I will be discussing in my third chapter. We are thrust immediately into the action in the first part of *TWF* entitled “The Warrior” which is three chapters long. Seven months have passed since the events of *TST* and once again, we are back in Toronto with the five university students. We know this because Jennifer was raped by Rakoth Maugrim at the end of *TST* and now she is “seven months heavy with the child” (*TWF* 266). Four of the students are waiting for Kim to have a dream or vision as their signal to go back to *Fionavar*. Jennifer, however, is only waiting for her labour to begin

because she intends “to die giving birth” (266). Paul convinces her to go to the Art Gallery with him where the two are attacked by Galadan, who has travelled to our world seeking to kill Jennifer and the child. Paul uses the powers he gained on the Summer Tree to take himself and Jennifer back to Fionavar.

The crossing induces Jennifer’s premature labour. Jennifer has Paul take her to the shop where Vae, Finn’s mother, lives so she can give birth there and leave her child with Vae. Darien is born in the shop. Paul finds the Priestess Jaelle and asks her and her order to keep watch over Darien because he is Rakoth Maugrim’s son and Paul fears that he will be dangerous. Jaelle sends Paul and Jennifer back to Toronto. Kim finally dreams of Stonehenge and the five Canadians travel there. Once at Stonehenge, Kim uses the Baelrath, the magical ring called the Warstone that Ysanne gave her, to summon the ghost of Uther Pendragon so that he can tell her his son Arthur’s secret name: Childslayer. Kim travels to Glastonbury Tor, formerly Avalon, and King Arthur’s resting place. She uses the last power of the Warstone to send the other four Canadians to Fionavar, then summons Arthur so that he can fight in Fionavar against the forces of evil. This part ends with the two of them crossing to Fionavar: Kim “crossed with Arthur Pendragon, the Warrior Condemned, to Fionavar and war” (286).

The Arthurian legends have always had an influence on the fantasy genre. Though Tolkien made little use of them in *The Lord of the Rings*, many authors, from Mary Stewart in her five-volume *Merlin* series (1970-1995) to Marion Zimmer Bradley’s *The Mists of Avalon* (1983), have drawn extensively on these legends. Kay taps into this fantasy tradition and weaves the stories of King Arthur, Guinevere and Lancelot into the last two volumes of his trilogy. Though respectful of the literary Arthurian tradition, Kay

wanted to change the way the story was told: “To the best of my knowledge, no one else has ever inverted 180 degrees the idea of the Once and Future King, as I ultimately do with the notion that Arthur is not resting among the blessed, our savior and champion in time of need, because of his greatness and glory. Rather I see him as cursed to return in our time of need at the cost of his own pain and grief” (Thompson). The reason for the curse, Kay states in an interview with Raymond H. Thompson, is the killing of the children in order to stop Mordred from being born: “[V]ital for me was to use the notion of Arthur as child slayer ... condemned to be the Once and Future King, the Warrior, by virtue of a crime in youth. The crime was not the incest ... It's the sentient ordering of the death of the children. That's the element of the story that gave me my curse on Arthur; that gave me access to the return of Guinevere and Lancelot as part of that curse” (Thompson). Kim's use of the name “Childslayer” to summon Arthur in *TWF* is our first glimpse of the change Kay makes to the well-known legend and our introduction to Arthur's curse. The Arthurian thread is important in the trilogy's narrative and especially in two of the sacrifices that I will discuss: Matt Sören's in this chapter and Prince Diarmuid's in Chapter Three.

The second part is entitled “Owein” and is six chapters long. This part features one of the sacrifices that I will discuss later in this chapter. After Paul, Kevin, Dave and Jennifer arrive in Fionavar they are taken to Aileron and discover that though it is only six days until Midsummer's Eve, an unnatural winter has been plaguing the land for nine months. The treacherous mage Metran is using the Cauldron of Khath Meigol, a great and destructive power the dwarves unearthed, to prolong the winter. They also discover that the Dalrei are being plagued by wolves. Aileron sends Diarmuid, his men, Dave, and

Kevin to help the Dalrei and also bring back Gereint, the shaman of Ivor's tribe, so that he can help determine how they might stop Metran and the Cauldron. During the battle to help the Dalrei, Kevin is reduced to the role of torch bearer, since he does not really know how to wield a sword, and feels useless.

Paul decides to check on Darien, Jennifer's son, discovers that the house where he left him has been abandoned, and fears something has happened to the child. Jaelle later tells him that she moved Darien, Vae and Finn to what was once Ysanne's cottage and that the Priestesses are keeping an eye on Darien through Laila, the girl who chose Finn in the ta'kiena in *TST* and who is now an initiate of Jaelle's order. Laila and Finn share a telepathic bond and in this way Laila is able to know whether or not Darien is in danger. Jaelle also tells Paul that, due to being andain, i.e., a demi-god, seven-month-old Darien "looks like a five-year-old child. And is growing faster now" (*TWF* 331). Paul worries that Darien will become a threat rather than a force of good as Jennifer hopes him to be. Darien's position between Light and Dark will become especially important in Chapter Three because it is this juxtaposition that is the root of his self-sacrifice.

Kim and Arthur arrive in Fionavar and present themselves to Loren and Matt. Shortly thereafter, Arthur and Kim are taken to Aileron and Arthur reveals more about his curse: he never lives long enough to see the end of any battle against the dark (335). Brendel, the lios alfar, brings Jennifer to Arthur and his recognition of her reveals that she is the reincarnation of Guinevere. Jennifer refuses to go to him because of her rape by Rakoth Maugrim, but believes her infidelity to Arthur cannot be re-enacted because the third point of their triangle, Lancelot, is not present.

A messenger arrives from Gwen Ystrat, the base of Jaelle's order, and requests aid from Aileron because they are also plagued by wolves. Aileron decides that he, Arthur, and a combined force from Brenninn and Cathal will go to Gwen Ystrat to hunt the wolves as soon as Diarmuid and his men return. Diarmuid does return, without Gereint who said he would meet them in Gwen Ystrat before they knew they were going there, and Kim's and Loren's suspicions that Diarmuid is the reincarnation of Lancelot are proven false. Before setting off for Gwen Ystrat, Levon suggests that since they now have Owein's Horn, Ceinwen's gift to Dave, and have discovered the place where the Wild Hunt slept, they should release the Sleepers so that they can fight in the last battle. Though they know very little about the Wild Hunt they decide to release them anyway. Kim, Diarmuid, Dave, Kevin, Paul and others set out for the cave where the Sleepers dwell and pass by Ysanne's cottage where Finn and Darien are playing out front. Only Paul knows who they are but Kevin waves in a friendly manner which Finn takes as a sign; eight riders and an acknowledgement from one means that this is the Longest Road, the mysterious destiny he was chosen for in the ta'kiena. When they reach the mouth of the cave, they find it blocked by a giant stone. Kim uses the Baelrath to remove the boulder and Dave blows the Horn to summon the Hunt. Eight ghostly riders, once kings, emerge and demand to know where the child is. Finn becomes that child as he steps up and takes his place with the Hunt, fading to mist and shadow like them. Finn's choice to sacrifice his mortal life will be analyzed later in this chapter.

The others leave for Gwen Ystrat and Paul goes to the cottage where Vae and Darien live, feeling a responsibility to tell Vae of Finn's fate, and a sense of wariness about Darien. This part ends with Paul discovering that Darien traced a flower in the snow and

coloured it by virtue of his magical andain powers. Darien lies in bed and hears voices in the wind, feeling betrayed that Finn left him (360).

The third part of *TWF* is called “Dun Maura” and is only two chapters long, though they are lengthy and important because they mainly concern Kevin and his sacrifice. The company arrives at Gwen Ystrat the day before Midsummer’s Eve (“Maidaladan”) and all the men are affected by a deep-seated lust that only grows stronger as Midsummer’s Eve approaches. This is linked to the power of Dun Maura, a cavern that is the seat of the Mother Goddess, Dana, whose power is tied to the power of the earth. Everyone feels the stirrings of desire except Kevin. He has always excelled at lovemaking, but in Fionavar he feels that he has been rendered not only useless but also impotent.

Before the combined armies go hunting in the woods, the magic users gather, with Kim leading them, to see if they can determine how Metran is using the Cauldron to create the winter and what they can do to stop it. Kim travels mentally into the depths of Maugrim’s evil, and sends back the image of the Cauldron. She also hears the chanting of Ruana, a Paraiko, of a race long thought to be dead, who helps her escape from the darkness but who also asks for her help in return: to save him and the remainder of his people. After Kim returns, Gereint and Loren determine that Metran must be using the Book of Nilsom, a powerful tome written by an evil mage, in conjunction with the Cauldron to cause the winter. Since Metran is on Cader Sedat, an unholy island in the middle of the sea, they cannot sail and reach him while the winter lasts.

During the wolf hunt on Midsummer’s Eve, Kevin is attacked by a massive white boar and wounded near his groin. This injury and the knowledge that no one can reach Cader Sedat while the winter lasts wakes something in Kevin and makes him realise

what he must do. He travels to Dun Maura and fulfills the ritual of Liadon, Dana's Beloved Son, which shares many similarities with those in Adonis myths which I explore to some extent later in this chapter. Kevin's union with the Mother Goddess and ultimate death ends the winter and spring comes.

The final part of *TWF* is entitled "Cader Sedat" and is five chapters long. Paul and Brendel take Darien to the grove of the Summer Tree so Paul can summon Cernan, God of the Beasts, and ask him to rapidly age Darien's body. Paul knows that Darien has a difficult choice to make, but is already coming into his power even though he is still in a child's body. Paul believes that Darien must grow up quickly, in mind and body, so that he will have a chance at controlling his power and making the right choice. Paul summons Cernan but during their discussion, Darien uses his own power to age his body so that it becomes that of an adolescent. Darien overhears that his father was Rakoth Maugrim and flees in bitterness and anger, shapeshifting into the form of an owl to get away.

Various characters mourn Kevin's death and Jennifer is no exception. She walks with Matt to the grave of Aideen, source to Nilsom who betrayed her mage and killed herself in order to save Brenninn and the Summer Tree. Jennifer does not believe she can find peace or hope because Arthur is here and she is always part of his curse. Matt entreats her: "'Never believe it!'... 'We are not slaves to the Loom. Nor are you only Guinevere – you are Jennifer now, as well. You bring your own history to this hour everything you have lived. You bring Kevin Laine within you and you bring Rakoth, whom you survived. You are here, and whole, and each thing you have endured has made you

stronger. It need not be now as it has been before!’” (417). Jennifer listens and heeds Matt’s advice.

Plans are made for a group to travel to Cader Sedat including Paul, Diarmuid, Loren, Matt, and Arthur, the only one who knows how to get to the island. Arthur believes that the battle at Cader Sedat may be what he has been summoned for this time and that he will die there. Jennifer decides that she will go to the Anor Lisen, the lighthouse on the edge of Pendaran Wood to wait for their return.

Aileron accompanies the group to Taerlindel, a port, therefore missing the warning the lios alfar of Daniloth send to Paras Derval of a great force of the armies of the dark sweeping across the Plain. When he receives word he takes a force of five hundred men to help the Dalrei in the battle and Dave, Torc and Levon go with him. The battle rages and it seems that the Dalrei are going to win until Avaia, the great black swan who transported Jennifer to Starkadh, attacks from the skies with her brood. Seemingly without another option, Dave blows Owein’s Horn and summons the Wild Hunt to battle. This works at first, because the Hunt kills many swans and cuts a swathe through the forces of the dark. After that, however, the Hunt turns on the Dalrei and the lios and begins killing them; only Ceinwen’s intervention prevents wholesale slaughter. She gives the Horn back to Dave with a warning not to use it again.

Cader Sedat is guarded by a sea monster, the Soulmonger, who attacks the ship. Loren shields the ship as best he can but it drains Matt’s energy and Paul knows he will not be able to maintain the shield for long. Paul calls on Liranan, the sea god, to help do battle against the Soulmonger but Liranan resists because the gods are not supposed to intervene in the Tapestry. With the help of Gereint, who sent his consciousness over the

sea to help give strength to Paul's summoning, Liranan is forced to comply. Before the monster is killed, Diarmuid retrieves the staff of Amairgen Whitebranch which he presents to Loren to use in the coming battle. It is the power of this staff and Matt's sacrifice that will allow Loren to triumph over Metran. With the Soulmonger defeated, they make their way to Cader Sedat where they witness Metran using the Cauldron as a source of power by draining the life force of a group of svart alfs, orc-like creatures. Metran is protected by a shield but Arthur, Loren, and Matt convince him to turn that power against them so that they may have a chance at destroying the Cauldron. Metran and Loren do battle and though Loren has the powerful mage's staff, he also only has the power that Matt can supply which will not be enough to defeat Metran without killing Matt. Matt decides to sacrifice his life energy to Loren, who uses it in a final blast that kills Metran and destroys the Cauldron.

Paul, Diarmuid and Arthur discuss Cader Sedat, the burial place of the great heroes from all the worlds. Arthur decides to go down to that tomb and wake Lancelot. Paul and Diarmuid both entreat him not to do this but Arthur feels compelled, knowing it is part of his doom. He wakes Lancelot from his death sleep and because Lancelot was recently dead himself, he is able to revive Matt Sören. *TWF* ends with the group leaving Cader Sedat and Arthur entreating Lancelot: "'Oh, Lance, come,' he said. 'She will be waiting for you'" (468). In spite of knowing the pain it will bring them all, Arthur knows he must bring Lancelot to Guinevere.

I will now focus more closely on the sacrifices I mean to discuss. The first involves Finn joining the Wild Hunt, thereby becoming a wraith and no longer able to live a mortal life. While this renders Finn immortal, this is not a good thing for him. Finn is

only fourteen years old, a kind boy who loves his adopted brother Darien. Finn's decision to give himself wholly to the Hunt means he can never return to the life he had as a teenage boy and will become little more than a ghostly embodiment of chaos whose only purpose is to cause death. While Finn does not necessarily know that is what will happen to him, he knows he will never be able to return to his former life. Finn still goes, making his action a willing self-sacrifice. That this action leads to his death in the third volume further emphasizes that it is a self-sacrifice.

Little is known about the Hunt but for an old verse, recited by Levon:

The flame will wake from sleep,
 The Kings the horn will call,
 But though they answer from the deep,
 You may never hold in thrall
 Those who ride from Owein's Keep
 With a child before them all. (346)

Loren offers little other information about the Hunt, only that they “were laid to rest an infinitely long time ago” (347) by the Paraiko, the Giants which Kay draws from Norse and Welsh mythology. Loren describes the Hunt as ““Shadowy kings on shadowy horses that could ride between the stars and between the Weaver's worlds”” (348). Matt supplies a dwarven legend that claims the Hunt moved the moon because “[t]hey wanted greater light by which to ride” (348). They speculate about how the Giants might have bound the Hunt in the cave and it is Paul, overtaken for a moment by a knowledge he cannot control, who explains: ““They lost the child. The ninth one. They were eight kings and a child. Then they made a mistake and lost the child, and in grief

and as penance they asked the Paraiko to bind them under the stone with whatsoever bonds they chose and whatsoever method of release” (348). Levon urges everyone to use the Horn and the Baelrath to release the Hunt but Loren cautions against it, noting that the Hunt ““is the wildest magic”” (349) and will not be easily controlled. It is not until Kim decides that they should release the Hunt that they realise they do not have the child, whom Owein asks for, and this is when Finn presents himself: “[Owein] whipped his horse, and with a cry it rose into the air above her.... ‘*Where is the child?*’ And then the world shifted again. It shifted in a way none of them, not one, neither mortal nor forest power nor watching god, had foreknown. From the fringe of trees not far from her a figure walked calmly forward. ‘Do not frighten her. I am here,’ said Finn. And so he came to the Longest Road” (352).

There are various myths and legends about a wild host or hunt filled with ghostly figures. In the third volume of *Teutonic Mythology* (1888), Jacob Grimm enumerates three different classes of this motif: “We have come to know the wild host in two principal lights: as a nocturnal hunt of male, and as a stately progress of female, deities; both, especially the last, occurring at stated season. The precise meaning of the word ‘host’ calls for a third explanation: it marches as an army, it portends the outbreak of war” (937). Grimm links these hosts with various historical kings and legends about them but adds “[t]here is more than one legend of enchanted mountains, in whose interior become audible, from time to time, drumming, piping and the clash of arms: an ancient host of spirits and gods is shut up inside, and is arming to sally out” (937). This is similar to Kay’s Hunt, shut up in a cave for thousands of years. Grimm’s only mention of a child in association with the Hunt is in relation to Orion. Grimm explains that

sometimes the myth of the hunt focused on a figure who loved hunting in life, so in Greek mythology, “Orion is struck blind, and is led to new light by Kedalion, a marvellous child who sits on his shoulders. Might not we match this blind giant with our headless wild hunter?” (949). Kay seems to have based his Hunt on a variety of existing legends about it.

The Wild Hunt is also somewhat similar to Tolkien’s Nazgûl. These latter are dead and ghostly: “So black were they that they seemed like black holes in the deep shade behind them. Frodo thought that he heard a faint hiss as of venomous breath and felt a thin piercing chill” (Tolkien, *Fellowship* 255). So, too, are the Wild Hunt: “In the space before the cave were seven shadowy figures, and each of them bore a crown and rode a shadowy horse, and the outline of each was blurred as through smoke” (*TWF* 351).

While Kay might have been inspired by Tolkien here, his Hunt is ultimately quite different from the Nazgûl, having no interest in serving Rakoth Maugrim as the Nazgûl serve Sauron. Moreover, the importance of Kay’s Hunt lies in its anarchic nature: it is a random thread in the Tapestry that serves neither good nor evil but only chaos. It has no purpose but to be random and can benefit either good or evil equally. This chaotic element links the Hunt not only to Diarmuid but also to Darien; this will be discussed further in my third chapter. Here, our concern with the Hunt is in connection to Finn.

In *TST*, Jennifer witnessed Finn being chosen by Laila for the third time to take the Longest Road in the children’s game the ta’kiena. Unbeknownst to her and Finn, the rhyme of the ta’kiena is linked to the verse about the Wild Hunt: “The ta’kiena had become skewed over the long years. It wasn’t four different children to four different fates. The wandering fire was the ring Kim wore. The stone was the rock it had smashed.

And all questions led to the Road that Finn had taken now” (357). On the day Kim and the others decide to wake the Hunt, Finn is uneasy all day. It is not until he communicates telepathically with Laila, however, that he realises this is the day that he will take the Longest Road. Laila asks Finn if he can feel something and he admits that he is uneasy: “And then his life began to end. For Leila sent ... an image. Of the ta’kiena on the green, when she had chosen him.... For a moment he quailed and could not hide it from her, but the moment passed.... He was deeply calm. He had had a long time to accept this thing and had been a long time waiting” (354). Finn knows that this is the day he is being called to his fate, even if he does not know what that fate is.

The use of the word *fate* regarding Finn may make it seem as if he has no choice in the matter and that his sacrifice is unwilling. This is not true, however, because Finn makes a conscious decision: “He had been marked. His legs would walk even if his heart and courage stayed behind. It was better, he knew, to have the heart and soul go, too, to make the offering run deeper and be true” (355). The use of the word *offering* here is interesting. While the passage states that Finn knows he will go whether he fully chooses to do so or not, the idea of making a true offering of himself is a decision he knows to be right. *Offering* also makes Finn’s decision a willing self-sacrifice since he freely chooses to embrace his fate. His destiny was not necessarily pre-ordained, either. An indication of this is in a passage when Kim is on her knees before Owein and just before Finn presents himself: “[The world] shifted in a way none of them, not one, neither mortal nor forest power nor watching god, had foreknown” (352). None of the powers in Fionavar, not even the “watching god” (who we can assume is the Weaver), knew that this was going to happen. Foreknowledge of this event would have made it seem much more

likely, though not necessarily fated, but there was no foreknowledge of this event making it seem more unlikely. That is to say, Finn could have had a different fate. His decision to offer himself fully to the Hunt, to take his place at their head and become a being no longer human, is what changed the Pattern and brought his fate about.

Finn's death in the third volume of the trilogy is arguably not part of his fate but his conscious choice as he tries to resist what he has become: "before them all ... rode the child on pale Iselen. The child that had been Finn dan Shahar. And who now was death" (*TDR* 742). At first, Finn is just as bloodthirsty as the rest of the hunt but Laila contacts him through their telepathic connection and summons him to her using the ancient power of Dana's sacrificial axe (743). This call gets through to Finn, to the boy he once was, and gives him the strength to turn his horse in Laila's direction. The horse fights him and he is thrown, landing hard on the ground and dying soon after in his father's arms. Finn's attempt to leave the Hunt throws them into disarray for long enough that Ruana can come to the battlefield and bind the Hunt once more. Finn's brief return to his conscious mind, through Laila's summons, allows him to make a choice that saves the lives of all those present on the battlefield who would have been slaughtered by the Hunt otherwise. His choice to join the Hunt and his death prove that his sacrifice was not only willing but also necessary.

The second sacrifice I am going to discuss in this chapter is that of Kevin Laine, who fulfills an ancient ritual and gives his life to end the unnatural winter. Of the three in *TWF*, Kevin's is the sacrifice most heavily based in ritual because it happens, and arguably must happen, at a specific time of year and with certain rites observed. Similar to many of the sacrifices in the trilogy, Kevin's is both paradoxically freely chosen and

has an element of fate to it. Kevin's is also the second and final sacrifice that combines Moshe Halbertal's notions of 'sacrificing to' and 'sacrificing for,' as Paul's did in my first chapter. Kevin sacrifices himself to Dana by completing the ritual, but in so doing he sacrifices himself for the rest of the world in order to end the winter. The destined element of Kevin's sacrifice is foreshadowed earlier in the volume. After the Canadians arrive in Fionavar again and Kevin and Dave participate in a battle with the Dalrei, Levon's sister Liane comes to Kevin and they sleep together: "And again, despite everything, the curving act of love took [Kevin] away with it, so far that the colours of the light seemed to change" (*TWF* 300). Whether Kevin is carried into himself or somewhere else by the pleasure is never fully explained. Regardless, Liane tries to reassure him that they only "went so deep because we are near to Gwen Ystrat" (300), the seat of power for the order of Dana's priestesses and their magic based in the earth. When Kevin explains that he always gets lost deeply in the act of love, Liane is surprised: "in a different voice [she] whispered, 'So you carry Dun Maura within yourself?' Then she called him, as he thought, drifting, by another name" (300). Kay does not reveal what this other name is but we learn later that it is Liadon.

Liadon is the equivalent of Adonis in Fionavar and the Priestesses perform the rites of Liadon, which entail singing a song of mourning and symbolically tearing at themselves in grief for the loss of the Beloved Son. J.G Frazer explains that the Greek myth of Adonis, the beautiful youth beloved by Aphrodite, actually derives from an older Babylonian myth where Adonis was called Tammuz which translates as "true son" or "true son of the deep water" (*Adonis* 8). Tammuz's death and revival signified the passing of the seasons and various rites were performed in his honour and laments sung

for him. Frazer explains that “the death of the god was annually mourned, with a bitter wailing, chiefly by women” (224) which mirrors the rites of Liadon in Fionavar where the priestesses chant “Rahod hedai Liadon!” (“Liadon has died again!”) (*TWF* 400).

Frazer also mentions how in the myth of Adonis “the fair youth was killed in hunting by a wild boar, or by the jealous Ares, who turned himself into the likeness of a boar in order to compass the death of his rival” (*Adonis* 11). This episode is mirrored in Kay when Kevin is hunting wolves and is attacked and nearly castrated by an enormous white boar. His sacrifice is foreshadowed after his injury in the sentence “there were droplets of his blood all over the snow like red flowers” (*TWF* 385). While he is only injured at this point, the injury, while symbolic of castration, prefigures his death and the spring flowers that will bloom once he has sacrificed himself.

Though Kevin is rehearsing an ancient sacrifice, that of Liadon for the Mother, the circumstances that cause him to make his sacrifice are rather unusual. There has never been an unnatural winter like this before in Fionavar and nobody knows how to stop it. There is still snow on the ground at Maidaladan, Midsummer’s Eve, when Kevin dies. It is only when Kevin learns what is causing the winter and how they cannot reach the Cauldron to stop it that he comes to realise what he must do. Just before Liane tells him about what the mages discovered, Kevin is uneasy: “[The moon] was full and this was Midsummer’s Eve, and the thing at the edge of his mind was pushing harder now, straining towards a shape” (387). He can sense that there is something he is going to have to do so he leaves the banquet hall. After Liane meets him in the street and tells him the winter is impossible to stop while it lasts, “It seemed to Kevin, then, that he had a vision of his past of chasing an elusive dream, waking or asleep, down all the nights of

his life. The pieces were falling into place. There was a stillness in his soul” (387). Like Finn who suddenly felt a sense of calm knowing his time had come, so too does Kevin realise on some level what is happening to him. He decides to go then and quietly saddles his horse to ride to Dun Maura.

While his fate seems to be calling him, there is nothing that compels Kevin to go. He could have resisted the call or pretended he did not hear it. It is the realization that he can be useful in Fionavar that guides him to make the choice to sacrifice himself. He sees it as a necessity and though he is influenced by that necessity, he still chooses his own fate. Kevin is not quite as calm as Finn when he goes to join the Hunt because he fears his own death: “His hands weren’t entirely steady. He took a number of slow, deep breaths and felt his heart’s beating ease.... He was very much afraid” (395). In spite of this fear, Kevin enters the cave which is warm and dark and follows a path that curves downward. He enters a dimly lit area and feels a pulse of power that finally awakens desire in him. Immediately after this, he meets a guardian who at first appears to be an old woman and greets him with the phrase, ““Bright your hair and bright your blood”” (396). This is the first line of the chant she utters later which is a riddle that the sacrificer, if he be true, must answer in order to proceed:

Bright your hair and bright your blood,
 Yellow and red for the Mother.
 Give me your name, Beloved,
 Your true name, and no other. (397)

Kevin offers his “true” name as Liadon and the guardian allows him to pass, pointing him towards a jagged rock and an old stone bowl. If Kevin wants his wish granted, and

he makes clear that he wishes for something, then he must offer blood. He cuts his cheek on the jagged rock and catches the blood in the bowl. This idea of a blood rite is reminiscent of E.O. James' idea of blood offerings as soul-substance which I discussed in my introduction.

This act fulfills the ritual and the crone, transformed now into a young woman, welcomes him and instructs him to pour out the blood, so that the Mother will come to fulfill his wish. She strips him naked and he goes to the edge of a chasm and pours into it the blood: "[H]e turned his whole being to the one wish of his heart, the one gift he sought of her in return, and he poured out the brimming cup of his blood into the dark chasm, to summon Dana from the earth on Midsummer's Eve" (398). Dana comes as summoned and embraces him as they fall down the chasm, fulfilling the rush of desire Kevin finally feels before he hits the bottom and dies. This violent plunge down the chasm recalls Girard, Hubert and Mauss's belief that violence is intrinsic to sacrifice. Kevin's death, like Ysanne's in the first chapter and Finn's earlier in this chapter, is violent. Kay does not emphasize the violence as such, however; the reasons for the violence are what he deems more important. Violence and killing become, as Kathryn McClymond points out, just another part of the ritual.

The last sacrifice I am going to discuss in this chapter is that of the dwarf, Matt Sören, who gives his life to defeat Metran and destroy the Cauldron of Khath Meigol. Matt's sacrifice is made possible because of Kevin's; without Kevin's death to end the winter, Matt and the others would not have been able to reach Cader Sedat. Until this point in the narrative, Matt has had a secondary function. He has almost always been present when Loren is and has imparted to various characters some small pieces of information

about the Summer Tree and the Wild Hunt. He also explained to Jennifer about the evil mage Nilsom and his source Aideen. Matt's history is not clarified until the end of *TST* when we discover that he was once King of the Dwarves. In order to become King, a dwarf must spend a night under a full moon beside Calor Diman, the Crystal Lake, and if he does not go mad he is crowned King (*TST* 247). Though Matt resigned his kingship because he was outvoted by the Dwarves who wanted to find the Cauldron of Khath Meigol, he still feels the pull of the Lake:

“When the King is bound to Crystal Lake,” Matt was explaining softly, “he is forever bound. There is no breaking it. He may leave but he is not free. The lake is in him like another heartbeat and it never stops calling. I lie down at night fighting this and rise up in the morning fighting it, and it is with me through the day and the evening and will be until I die. This is my burden, and it is mine alone, and I would have you know, else I would not have spoken before you, that it was freely chosen and is not regretted” (248-49).

Matt's history is important not only to events in the third volume of the trilogy but also if we are to make sense of his sacrifice at the end of *TWF*.

Throughout both volumes, there is an obvious intimacy between Matt and Loren both as mage and source and as friends. This connection is one that Matt clearly takes very seriously. Though he brings the first flowers to Aideen's grave every year, he still vilifies her for breaking her connection with her mage even though her actions saved Brennin. His devotion to being a good source is a major part of Matt's character and plays a crucial role in his sacrifice. This devotion is similar to Ysanne's devotion to being the Seer of Brennin and doing what needs to be done to help Fionavar.

After Kim's spiritual quest into the source of the unnatural winter and Loren's discovery that Metran is using the book of Nilsom in conjunction with the Cauldron of Khath Meigol, Ivor observes: "In Matt Sören's one eye he saw a gleam of the same pride with which [his wife] sometimes looked at him. Quietly, the Dwarf said 'I knew you would. We have a battle then?'" (*TWF* 377). Just as Aileron has claimed ownership of the war they are going to fight against the dark, Loren and Matt claim this particular battle against Metran and his source, Denbarra. When Loren explains how Metran is channeling the power of all the svart alfar that he is draining and reviving through Denbarra, Paul asks why Denbarra would allow this. Matt quickly turns on him: "Because a source does not betray his mage!' They all heard the bitterness" (450). Only a moment later, Loren asks Matt what he would have done if Loren had been the treacherous mage instead of Metran: "'Cut your heart out!' Matt Sören said. Loren looked at his source, a smile beginning to play about his mouth. 'Would you?' he asked. For a long time Matt glared back at him. Then he grimaced and shook his head" (450). Matt is undoubtedly a moral person but his bond with Loren is so strong and his investment in the rule about sources betraying their mages so absolute that even if Loren were to do great evil, Matt would not be able to harm him.

Matt's dedication to his and Loren's battle against Metran is absolute. By the time they reach Cader Sedat, his energy is already considerably drained. Loren had to maintain a magical shield to protect the ship against the Soulmonger and then had to use a magically propelled wind in order for them to reach the island. Both of these acts took a toll on Matt so he is not at his strongest or healthiest when Metran and Loren start to battle. Loren and Matt are considerably outmatched not only because of Matt's

weakened state but also because Metran is drawing on considerably more lives to fuel his magic than just his source. Through the Cauldron, he has limitless power and energy from the svart alfar that are continually dying and being reanimated. Even though he wields the staff of Amairgen Whitebranch, Loren is losing the battle, Metran's green bolt of power steadily pushing back Loren's silver one. Paul helps in the only way he can, supporting Matt while the dwarf's energy is consistently drained: "Then [Paul] saw that none of it was enough. Not courage, wisdom, prayer, necessity. Not one against so many. Slowly, with brutal clarity, the silver thrust of power was being pushed back towards them" (463).

Loren falls back and would lose if not for Matt, who suddenly makes a decision for them:

Matt Sören spoke. With an effort so total it almost shattered Paul's heart, the Dwarf forced sounds out of his chest. "Loren," he gasped, his face contorted with strain. "Loren...do now!" The green surge of Metran's might leaped half a foot nearer to them.... "Loren," Matt mumbled again. "I have lived for this. Do it now." The Dwarf's one eye was closed. He trembled continuously.... "Matt," [Paul] heard the mage say. "Oh, Matt." The name nothing more.... Looking up, he saw Loren's face distort with wildest hate. He heard the mage cry out then, tapping into his uttermost power, sourced in Matt Sören the Dwarf, channelled through the Whitebranch of Amairgen, and the very heart and soul of Loren Silvercloak were in that cry and in the blast that followed it. (463)

The final surge of power that takes Matt's life succeeds in killing Metran and shattering the Cauldron of Khath Meigol. It is a significant victory for the light but it comes at a

high cost: Matt's life and Loren's status as a mage. The bond between Matt and Loren is severed when Matt dies which means that Loren can no longer use magic. It is a price they were both willing to pay, however, in order to defeat Metran's evil. Matt went willingly but, looking at his body afterwards, Paul notices "in the Dwarf's face, dead, a thing he had never seen in it, living: Matt Sören smiled amid the ruin of Cader Sedat, not the grimace they had learned to know but the true smile of one who has had what he most desired" (464). In death, Matt finds the peace he could never achieve in life because of the constant pull the Crystal Lake had on him as rightful King of the Dwarves.

Matt does not remain dead, however, though he expected to. Like Paul, Matt is able to return to life because of Lancelot, whom Arthur wakes from his death sleep. While Paul was able to return from his sacrifice because of the intervention of a god, Matt is able to return through the intervention of a legendary figure. Matt's sacrifice is even more significant because he is only one of two characters that is able to return from death. Like Paul, he had no foreknowledge that he was going to come back to life and thought he was giving up everything in order to defeat Metran. Halbertal points out that "it is the mark of the good that it deserves sacrifice" (69) when he discusses 'sacrificing for' and this is certainly true in Matt's case; he believes he is doing good and is willing to give up his life for that good. Matt felt that he was supposed to die in that battle, found peace when he did, but he still had more to do and so Lancelot defied "the movement of the wheel of time and the shuttling of the Loom" (*TWF* 467) to bring him back.

The importance of the three sacrifices I have discussed in this chapter is evident. Without Finn's choice to join the Hunt, the lios alfar and the Dalrei would have been

defeated at the battle on the Plain because there would have been no one to answer the call when Dave blew the Horn. Finn's death in the third volume marks the end of the immortality he supposedly gained when joining the Hunt which makes it a curse rather than a blessing. Kevin is clearly fated to be Liadon but he does not simply fulfill the ritual and his destiny; he uses the sacrifice to help the others to end the winter so that Loren and Matt can get to Cader Sedat and stop Metran. Without Kevin's sacrifice, they would not have been able to end the winter or stop Metran from continuing to use the Cauldron. If the winter had not ended, it would have been impossible for the armies of Light to move forward, and the Dark would have won. Therefore, Kevin's willing self-sacrifice is necessary to complete the World Tapestry in a satisfactory way. Matt's sacrifice too is necessary but so is his revival by Lancelot because Matt has a crucial role to play in the third volume of the trilogy. All three sacrifices were freely chosen and that choice is what gives the sacrifices their power.

CHAPTER THREE: An Analysis of *The Darkest Road*

In this final chapter, I am going to examine the last volume of *The Fionavar Tapestry*, *The Darkest Road*. The two sacrifices here are arguably the most important expressions in the trilogy of sacrifice as an exercise of free will and how that expression of free will changes the World Pattern for the better. Diarmuid dan Ailell, Prince of Brennin, and Darien, son of Jennifer and Rakoth Maugrim, are the two characters who make the willing self-sacrifices I will examine in this chapter.

Unlike the other two volumes, *TDR* has five parts instead of four, making it the longest of the three. The first part entitled “The Last Kanior” is three chapters long. Kim and her companions, Brock, Faebur and Dalreidan, arrive in Khath Meigol. The Paraiko, trapped in caves, are being killed with smoke and starvation by svart alfar. The svarts are killing them this way, under Galadan’s instruction, to avoid the curse that the pacifist Paraiko put on anyone who sheds their blood. To defeat the svarts, Kim summons Imraith-Nimphais. Tabor comes riding on the unicorn and they slaughter the svart alfar though Kim knows that “it was destroying them both” (520) because Tabor becomes less human each time he rides Imraith-Nimphais. Once the giants are freed, Ruana performs the kanior, a song-spell that is a lament for the dead and a way to seek absolution for wrongs done. This rite is necessary to maintain the bloodcurse that is the Paraiko’s only form of protection since they are completely non-violent. The Baelrath blazes and Kim realises she has been brought here to change the Paraiko: to make them able to hate by showing them images of Jennifer’s rape and torture by Rakoth Maugrim in Starkadh and so call them to war. Learning hate costs the Giants the bloodcurse and the kanior, and Ruana vows that they will not kill but will help by cleansing Eridu of the plague brought

on by the death rain. They have a more important part to play later when Ruana comes to the battlefield to bind Owein and the Wild Hunt once more.

Jennifer and Brendel travel to the Anor Lisen, the tower from which Lisen watched for Amairgen's return and leapt to her death when he never came. They meet Flidais, a wood sprite who Jennifer recognizes from Camelot as Taliesin, another name for Merlin. Flidais disturbs the flowers that Galadan left there which alerts Galadan that someone is in the Tower, drawing him to it. In Brennin, Jaelle learns that Leila is still connected to Finn and can sense him while the Wild Hunt rides. Jaelle warns Leila to break the link because "there is a death in it" (*TDR* 497) which Jaelle knows to be true since "[i]t was her own voice, and more than her own. Hers and the Goddess's. Which meant, always, that what she said was true" (497). Jaelle's warning foreshadows Finn's death later in the novel.

Dave reunites with Torc and Levon on the Plain. We learn from Torc the name and some of the nature of an urgach in white, Uathach. Torc makes Levon promise never to go after him because "[h]e is too big ... and too quick and something more than both of those'" (500). The chieftains of the Dalrei hold a War Council with Ra-Tenniel, Lord of the lios alfar, and Aileron. They agree to take the whole of the army to Andarien, the plain before Starkadh that was the site of the last war with Maugrim. Ra-Tenniel assures the chieftains that the lios alfar will ride with them, ensuring that Maugrim will attack them there and not the unprotected areas behind the armies. Maugrim will not be able to resist attacking them because they are "[m]ost hated by the Dark, for their name was Light" (507). After the war council has concluded, Galadan reflects on Uathach: "Six months ago [he] had been summoned to Starkadh ... He had come out again four nights

ago, augmented, enhanced in some unsettling way. He was clever now, vicious and articulate” (508). Galadan makes for Lisen’s Tower and this part ends with Tabor and Imraith-Nimphais taking Kim to Ysanne’s cottage.

The second part entitled “Lisen’s Tower” is six chapters long. It begins with the ship that sailed to Cader Sedat making its way home. Lancelot duels with his shadow on the deck of the ship and Diarmuid challenges him, inserting himself into the fate of Arthur, Lancelot, and Guinevere as he did when Arthur woke Lancelot from his death sleep. Lancelot defeats Diarmuid and though the prince attempts to lighten the mood, Arthur and Lancelot are again reminded of their doom. This moment foreshadows Diarmuid’s role in the fate of the Arthurian triad which I will analyze in more detail later in this chapter. Kim has a dream about why Ysanne made her a Seer but does not completely understand it. She goes down to the secret room underneath the cottage, takes out the Circlet of Lisen, and is confronted by Darien. Kim knows the Circlet belongs to him and tells him that it is the Light against the Dark. The Circlet once belonged to Lisen, a nymph born long ago in Pendaran Wood who was an embodiment of Light. She wore it and stood at the top of the Anor Lisen where the light of the Circlet was a beacon in the darkness. Presumably some of her essence is infused into the Circlet. Thanks to Ysanne, Kim knows, but does not tell Darien, that whoever wears the Circlet next “shall have the darkest road to walk of any child of earth or stars” (545). Kim places the Circlet on Darien’s brow and its light goes out. This convinces Darien that he is evil and should go to his father so he steals the magical dagger, Lökdal, and leaves. Sharra and Jelle arrive at the cottage and Kim tells them what happened. Sharra makes Kim realise how lonely Darien must be, so she shouts that Jennifer, Darien’s mother, is at a tower in Pendaran

Wood in the hope that Jennifer will stop Darien from going to Maugrim. The three women decide they should warn Jennifer of Darien's possible arrival and travel to Lisen's Tower. Darien flies to the Tower in the form of an owl.

Flidais explains to Jennifer that the Wild Hunt was meant to be the random thread in the Tapestry, thus enabling mortals to have free will. He also explains how their presence allowed Maugrim to enter the Tapestry. Rakoth Maugrim is the price that everyone pays in order to have freedom of choice (557-8). Because the Weaver allowed there to be a thread of randomness in the Tapestry, a randomness which allows for the possibility of free will, Maugrim was able to come from outside and enter the Tapestry. Darien comes to the Wood and Jennifer, Brendel and Flidais go down to meet him. Darien shyly offers her the magical dagger but Jennifer rebuffs him because she believes he must be kept from being bound to either good or evil. Darien takes the rejection hard and is convinced that he belongs with the Dark. Flidais extracts the summoning name of the Warrior from an unwilling Kim and vows that he will do good because of it.

The ship from Cader Sedat is battered by a terrible storm which Paul realises is the Weaver's sent to force the ship to the Anor Lisen and so bring Arthur and Lancelot to Jennifer. Paul summons Liranan just as the ship crashes on the rocks and Liranan calms the waters of the bay so that the passengers survive. Lancelot comes onto the beach carrying Arthur, and Jennifer meets them, realising that their doom will play out once more since all three of them are there (570-71). Jennifer tells him what happened to her in Starkadh and about Darien's existence then asks him to leave. Lancelot vows to follow and guard Darien but not bind him or try to influence his choice.

The army of Brennin arrives at Celidon, the meeting place of the Dalrei. Jennifer tells Arthur about Darien and Kim feels guilty about breaking her oath to him but he forgives her, mentioning that Flidais is clearly part of the story since he was Taliesin in Camelot. Matt and Loren decide to go to Banir Lök, city of the Dwarves, so Matt can reclaim his crown. The Baelrath's glow alerts Kim to the fact that she must go with them and she transports the three of them there by the power of the Warstone.

Diarmuid decides they should move around Pendaran Wood since Aileron will not wait for them to meet the assembled armies at the borders of Andarien. Paul and Jaelle spot a ghost ship out in the bay and when they walk across the water to meet it, they discover that it is the ship of Amairgen Whitebranch who has come to deliver the King's Spear to Arthur, summoned by Jennifer's presence in Lisen's Tower. Paul releases Amairgen from his ghostly bondage because the Soulmonger's death avenges Amairgen, but Jaelle binds him further, tasking him to deliver the King Spear directly to Arthur. Amairgen agrees and the company boards the ship. This event reflects the episode in Tolkien's *The Return of the King* when Aragorn travels the Paths of the Dead (1029-34). Heroes in both Tolkien and Kay must interact with the dead which is a significant similarity. Both times the dead, who are trapped in the world as ghosts, are released from their respective curses by performing redemptive tasks. This is a significant similarity between the two trilogies because it demonstrates how important the legacy of the dead was to the earlier medieval traditions both draw from though I do not have space to discuss this further here.

Darien is led to a sacred grove in Pendaran Wood where an earth demon, Curdardh, intends to kill him. Darien realises the danger, but he goes willingly because he is sad,

lonely, and intimidated by the choice he is supposed to make. He believes it is better to abstain from choosing, and end his miserable existence. Curdardh appears, intent on killing Darien, but Lancelot steps in to defend him and the battle begins.

While the battle rages, Flidais appears and tells Darien about Lökdal and its magical powers. After a long battle, Lancelot, nearly beaten, enlists Darien's help. Darien's scream gives Lancelot the opportunity to sever Curdardh's arm, pick up the dropped hammer, and throw it at the demon, killing it. Darien flies away again as an owl and Lancelot resolves to follow him even though he is severely injured. Flidais makes Lancelot agree to let him tend his wounds and then guides him to Daniloth, the Shadowland of the lios alfar where time passes differently. Lancelot follows him and Pendaran Wood honours his passage, concluding this part.

The third part is entitled "Calor Diman" and is comprised of four chapters. Kim, Loren and Matt arrive outside the doors leading to the Kingdom of the Dwarves where they are attacked and the Baelrath is taken from Kim. The Dwarfmoot meets, similar to the Entmoot in Tolkien, and judges a debate between Matt and Kaen. The Dwarfmoot concludes that they will leave the decision about who should lead them to Calor Diman. The Crystal Dragon rises out of the Lake and chooses Matt as the true king, killing Kaen. The Baelrath blazes on Kim's finger and she understands that she is supposed to summon the Dragon to the war against the Dark. Such an invocation would not only destroy Dwarven tradition and culture but also the protection the Crystal Dragon has always given to the Dwarves. Kim refuses to use the Baelrath for this purpose and instead uses it to transport herself and Loren, Matt, and Miach of the Dwarfmoot to a forest in Gwynir. The Dwarven army stands down and Matt, after challenging Blöd to

single combat, kills him. Matt declares that the Dwarves are no longer servants of the Dark and will join Aileron's army.

Meanwhile, Diarmuid and company sail on Amairgen's ghost ship and Arthur guides them to shore by the light of the King Spear. Amairgen and his ship are finally freed from wandering the seas and disappear. Lancelot is guided through Daniloth and prevails upon his guide to free Darien, suspended in owl form in the mist. She complies and Darien continues on his journey. Leyse leads Lancelot out of Daniloth where he waits by Celyn lake until he reunites with Diarmuid and the others.

The fourth part entitled "Andarien," is four chapters long, details the final battle between Light and Dark, and is the most important for my thesis because both sacrifices I will be discussing occur in this part. Arriving at the battlefield, Aileron finds the incalculably vast army of the Dark already there. Uathach issues a challenge to the army and insults Jennifer. Arthur prepares himself to fight, believing that he is to die in battle. Jennifer forbids him and requests that Lancelot go instead but before he can act Diarmuid rides out to face Uathach. Diarmuid kills Uathach but dies from the wounds he sustained in battle and this act allows for Arthur to survive the battle and changes the long doom that has been laid upon him.

The army of Light is outnumbered and despairs when Rakoth Maugrim's Dragon appears in the sky. Kim realises that it was because of this Dragon that the Baelrath, now gone dark and cold on her finger, compelled her to summon the Crystal Dragon of the Dwarves. Imraith-Nimphais and Tabor make themselves "into a living blade" (726) and fly straight towards the Dragon. Just before impact, Imraith-Nimphais bucks Tabor in order to save him from that death. He nearly dies anyway, falling from such a height, but

Arthur catches him, in part redeeming himself for the death of the other children in Camelot long ago. The hope that arises when the Dragon is killed is immediately extinguished when reinforcements for the forces of the Dark arrive.

Darien has entered Starkadh by this point and comes before his father. Maugrim assaults him mentally, but Darien manages to withhold the secret of his identity and offers his father the dagger Lökdal. Maugrim takes this gift but mocks it, while Darien sees that the windows of the chamber reflect what is happening on the battlefield. Recognizing Lancelot, his foster father, Paul, and Jennifer, Darien realises he does not want any of them to die and numbers himself among the forces of Light for the first time. Darien's recognition of Jennifer reveals his identity to Maugrim who resolves to kill his son, explaining that "A child of my seed binds me into time! It puts my name in the Tapestry, and I can die!" (736). Before killing him, however, Maugrim reaches for the Circlet of Lisen, which suddenly blazes with light. The light hurts Maugrim and forces him to release his mental hold on Darien, allowing Darien to impale himself on Lökdal, which Maugrim still holds. Because Maugrim kills without love in his heart, the magic of the dagger destroys him. Darien dies hoping that someone will tell Jennifer that he made the right choice.

With Maugrim dead, the forces of the Dark seem broken. Galadan steals Owein's Horn from Dave and blows it, summoning the Hunt who intend to indiscriminately slaughter everyone. Leila, acting High Priestess in the Temple in Brennin, is still connected to Finn and summons him. Finn, riding with the Hunt, does not react at first but when Leila uses the sacrificial axe in the Temple and calls him with the power of Dana, Finn cannot resist and attempts to turn his horse away from the battle. The Hunt is

distraught and the horse fights his guidance and throws him. Unseated, Finn changes back from his shadowy form into a mortal who hits the ground and dies in his father's arms. The Hunt despairs but Owein reveals that since they are no longer bound, they do not need the child. Ruana appears to fulfill what the Warstone summoned the Paraiko to do: bind Owein and the Hunt once more. The Hunt is bound and the crisis is averted.

After the battle, Paul summons Liranan, who brings sea waters bearing Flidais in a boat to the battlefield. Paul explains that Arthur's doom is finally transformed because of Diarmuid's sacrifice and that the king is finally able to rest in glory. Arthur, Jennifer, Lancelot and Cavall sail off into the peaceful sky and this part concludes.

The last part, "Flowerfire," is only one chapter long and serves as an epilogue. Dave, Kim, and Paul make their farewells as they try to decide whether they will return to our world or stay in Fionavar. Dave meets Ceinwen one final time who tells him that he must go back to his world because "no man of Fionavar may see Ceinwen hunt" (764). Kim relinquishes the Baelrath to Aileron and resolves to return home, knowing that she will now always be a Seer and carry Ysanne's soul within her. Paul is resolved to return to our world but realises not only that he will always be the Arrow of Mornir but also that he and Jaelle love one another, so that he will stay after all. The trilogy ends with Dave asking Kim out on a date when they have returned to Toronto. Since the climactic battle has already taken place, ending the trilogy here with hope of a return to normalcy is fitting. Sarah Clements points out how this ending is still somewhat ominous: "Kay ends his novels with a measure of hope – the possibility of a date on Saturday night – but all hope must be tempered by the sure knowledge of more sacrifices to come. Maugrim is defeated, but the Tapestry can still be random, and good must always be balanced with

evil” (Clements). Far from being anti-climactic, the trilogy ends on a hopeful note with the caveat that there will be battles in the future even though the Light has just won a major victory.

The two major acts of willing self-sacrifice in this volume are what Sean David McKenzie calls “the two pure sacrifices” (120). McKenzie sees the other sacrifices in the trilogy, notably Paul’s and Kevin’s, as impure because there is often a selfish motive involved. Diarmuid’s and Darien’s sacrifices, according to McKenzie, “serve as models, and legends ... to create something infinitely pure and beautiful, free of coercion or selfishness, willing self-condemnations to the darkest of roads in order to set others free to bask in the light” (126). I do agree that the actions of Diarmuid and Darien in *TDR* are pure in that predestination does not seem to play a part in them; both of their sacrifices depend entirely upon their own choices. I disagree with McKenzie, however, about the other sacrifices. In Chapter One, I explained that though Paul’s sacrifice does include selfish motives it is not invalidated because of that; he still chooses to complete the sacrifice rather than die before it is finished. In Chapter Two, I discussed Kevin’s sacrifice and how it seemed fated but was also freely chosen; while Kevin’s fate called to him he could have ignored or resisted that call. Regardless, McKenzie’s point is useful here because Diarmuid’s choice results in the freedom of Arthur, Guinevere and Lancelot, while Darien’s saves not only Fionavar but also all the other worlds that reflect it.

Throughout the trilogy, Diarmuid’s manner and many of his actions are extravagant and often unpredictable. Though he appears almost always to be frivolous and half drunk, Diarmuid has moments of sternness and clear command. For example, in *TST*

when a farmer blesses Diarmuid, saying “‘And in the name of the Summer Tree, may [Mörnir] take the old man and let you be our King!’” (*TST* 65), Diarmuid reacts severely and unexpectedly coldly: “There was a brutal silence. The Prince’s face had gone cold.... Diarmuid’s voice, when it came, was formal and imperious. ‘The words you have spoken are treason,’ Ailell’s son said, and with a sideways nod spoke one word more: ‘Coll.’ The farmer may never have seen the arrow that killed him” (65). While this sudden death sentence for a farmer who seemed only to be trying to express his affection for Diarmuid is shocking, and disgusting to Kevin, Diarmuid explains his action later: “‘And,’ said the Prince, his voice still light, ‘it is a mistake to make judgements too soon. That man had to die – had he not, word would be in the palace by now that I was encouraging treasonous talk.... His life was forfeit from the time he spoke, and the arrow was a kinder death than Gorlaes would have granted him’” (68). Diarmuid’s was an act of mercy, and everything he does is calculated and purposeful, even if it does not always appear so.

Another example in *TDR* of Diarmuid’s supposed frivolity that is actually purposeful is when the ship is returning from Cader Sedat. Seeing Lancelot duelling with his own shadow, Diarmuid challenges him, though as they have no practice wooden swords on board they will have to use actual blades. Loren admonishes Diarmuid, “‘this is hardly the time for games, let alone dangerous ones’” (*TDR* 537) but Diarmuid easily counters him: “‘We are at sea,’ he said to Loren with exaggerated reasonableness, ‘and at least a day’s sailing, perhaps more ... from reaching land. There may never be a more felicitous occasion for play’” (537). Lancelot agrees to the duel and, to further the joke, Diarmuid salutes Lancelot and cries “‘For the sacred honour of the Black Boar!’” (537). (This is

his favourite tavern in Paras Derval.) The mood shifts when Lancelot declares for the Queen and Paul looks to Arthur who seems to be ignoring the duel.

The duel goes on and Paul comes to a realization: “He thought about interceding ... but even with the thought he became aware of his own racing pulse, of the degree to which Diarmuid had just lifted him – all of them – into a mood completely opposite to the hollow silence of fifteen minutes before.... The Prince, he realized, knew exactly what he was doing” (538). When Lancelot inevitably beats Diarmuid in spite of the latter’s trickery, Paul notes “the smile on the Warrior’s face and the answering gleam in Lancelot’s eyes, and again he saluted Diarmuid inwardly” (539). In spite of Diarmuid’s attempts, the mirth is shattered when Arthur and Lancelot briefly discuss Gawain and are reminded of their tragic history. Paul notes that “the doom of these two men and the woman waiting for them was far too intricately shaped to be lifted, even briefly, by access to laughter or joy” (539). This observation imperfectly echoes Tolkien’s notion of eucatastrophe as “joy ... poignant as grief” (“On Fairy-Stories” 153). In this instance, Diarmuid succeeds only momentarily in distracting or changing the doom of Arthur, Lancelot and Guinevere, though his self-sacrifice later will end it.

This instance on the ship is not the first time that Diarmuid has tried to intercede or in some way change this doom. At the end of *TWF*, when Arthur is about to wake Lancelot from his death sleep, Diarmuid protests: “‘My lord Arthur,’ . . . ‘you do not have to do this. It is neither written nor compelled’” (465). Diarmuid’s nature, as Kay has often stated (“Afterword”), is anarchic in spite of his role as heir to the throne of Brennin. That Arthur seems compelled to bring about his own doom is anathema to Diarmuid. This

scene, though brief, is the first hint of Diarmuid's resistance against the doom of the Arthurian triad.

Diarmuid's death is the first in the final battle between the armies of Light and Dark and is very significant in terms of changing the World Pattern through an act of self-sacrifice. From the second volume where the Arthurian legends are introduced to nearly the end of the third volume, the narrative emphasizes how long Arthur's doom (and therefore Lancelot's and Guinevere's) has been fixed, how many repetitions of it there have been, and how tragic it is. It seems inevitable, unchangeable, since death is the price Arthur must always pay for the death of the children in Camelot. Diarmuid, however, manages to change that fate and therefore the very weave of the World Tapestry through his act of willing self-sacrifice.

Uathach, the overly large *urgach* who has somehow been changed in Starkadh and made smarter, issues a challenge to Arthur at the outset of the battle. The creature taunts Arthur and Lancelot, insulting Jennifer by mentioning that Avaia, the terrible black swan, will again bring her to her rapist Maugrim (*TDR* 700). Arthur takes the challenge upon himself, readying himself for the battle since he believes this is his destined time to die. Jennifer protests but Arthur tries to silence her: "'We are caught in a woven doom of no escape. You know I must go down to him'" (701). Jennifer asks Lancelot to go in Arthur's stead and a painful argument breaks out between the three of them who become oblivious even to Paul's attempts to intercede. Paul, listening to this painful exchange, notices a sudden absence by his side and then wheels around to see Diarmuid charging down to face Uathach:

[Paul] saw. And then he heard, they all heard, as a ringing cry rose up, echoing in the twilight air between the armies of Light and Dark:

“For the Black Boar!” he heard. They all heard. *“For the honour of the Black Boar!”*

And thus did Diarmuid dan Ailell take Uathach’s challenge upon himself, riding forth alone on the horse his brother had brought for him, his sword uplifted high, his fair hair lit by the sunset, as he raced towards the dance his bright soul would not deny. (702)

As before on the ship, Diarmuid intervenes in the doom that is not his own, defying its inevitability. His “bright soul” refuses to allow this doom to continue and therefore he rides into a hopeless battle wherein he will certainly die, but he will save the three legendary figures he has come to know and respect.

Watching Diarmuid’s final battle, Paul reflects about how there was “[e]xtravagance always, the flamboyant gesture masking so many deeper truths. But the truths were there to be seen, if one only knew where to look.... Always the gesture, the deflecting glitter of style, hiding what he was, at root, behind the last locked doorway of his soul” (704). Though it is not explicitly stated, Diarmuid seems to be at the root of his soul a Light against the Darkness, a resistance to the woven patterns of the Tapestry, an expression of a noble, wild passion for life and of a hatred for the Dark. Hence Diarmuid’s final act: “Because it was for Arthur and Lancelot, and for Guinevere, that Diarmuid, in all the wild anarchy of his nature, had claimed this dance as his own. It was against the weaving of their long doom that he had defiantly rebelled, and had channelled that rebellion into

an act of his own against the Dark. Taking Uathach unto himself, that Arthur and Lancelot, both, might go forward past this day” (705).

Diarmuid’s final sacrifice is powerful enough to save Arthur and Lancelot from this battle so that they might find peace with Guinevere. Diarmuid, like the Wild Hunt and in some ways like Darien, is a random element in the Tapestry and through his choice he changes the Pattern for the better:

Paul said, “You told us the pattern, Warrior. How it has always been, each and every time you have been summoned. Arthur, it has changed. You thought you were to die at Cader Sedat and you did not. Then you thought to find your ending in battle with Uathach, and you did not.”

“I think I was supposed to find it there,” Arthur said, his first words.

“I think so, too,” Paul replied. “But Diarmuid chose otherwise. He made it *become* otherwise. We are not slaves to the Loom, not bound forever to our fate.

Not even you, my lord Arthur. Not even you, after so long.” (753)

Paul clearly puts emphasis on the fact that Diarmuid’s choice to sacrifice his life was strong enough to change even the seemingly interminable doom laid out for the legendary Arthurian figures. The Pattern, then, and fates that seem unchangeable, can be ameliorated by such acts.

Susannah Clements further argues this point. She states that the Arthurian figures being allowed to sail away in peace because of Diarmuid’s sacrifice is “a final triumph of free will over fate” (Clements). I agree that Diarmuid’s ability to change the doom of the Arthurian figures with an act of self-sacrifice is a very strong indication that free will can and does change or triumph over fate. Where I differ from Clements is in

maintaining that the only way the Tapestry, or fate, can play out as it is actually meant to is through willing self-sacrifice. By contrast, Tolkien seems only to require there to be a eucatastrophe in order for fate to play out as it is meant to. While there is one notable willing self-sacrifice in Tolkien's trilogy, Gandalf's death when he fights the Balrog, willing self-sacrifice in general does not play as crucial a role in Tolkien as it does in Kay. Clements acknowledges that in Kay's work as well as that of most other fantasy writers, sacrifices must be made in order for good to triumph. For Kay, however, what gives these sacrifices their power is that they must be willingly made.

Diarmuid's is also the most violent sacrifice in the trilogy since he dies of wounds inflicted from a long battle instead of one sacrificial killing stroke. Halbertal has an interesting insight about the violence of war and self-sacrifice: "Human beings are the only species that kills for principle rather [than] for self-interest ... the connection between sacrifice and violence is that war is not embarked on despite the risk and sacrifice that it involves; it is strengthened and motivated by this aspect. There is, in other words, a deep internal (and not accidental) connection between killing and self-sacrifice" (68). This insight seems to be an inversion of what one would expect, that there is a connection between *dying* and self-sacrifice, not killing. Since Halbertal is discussing war here, however, it makes sense. It also makes sense in Diarmuid's case; his sacrifice involves a death other than his own. While the motivations for the war Diarmuid is involved in are purer than the motivations Halbertal discusses, it is still a useful connection to make. Diarmuid's self-sacrifice involves a battle whereas the others, aside from Matt Sören's, do not.

Arguably the most important self-sacrifice of the trilogy is Darien's. Conceived during Rakoth Maugrim's rape of Jennifer, Darien has a difficult road from the beginning. Prematurely aged into the body of a teenager, he is barely a year old when he gives up his short but tortured existence. Darien is an andain, the child of a mortal and a god, and therefore has supernatural powers and grows much faster than most. At only seven months, he is already as big as a five-year-old child. After naming him, Jennifer decides to give him to Vae, Finn's mother, so she can raise him and love him. Jennifer does not raise Darien herself because her hope is to keep him as a random thread in the Tapestry, not to bind him to choose good or evil one way or another but to leave the choice entirely up to him. She can surely be forgiven for giving Darien to a loving home and thus biasing him towards the Light, even if this seems inconsistent with her insistence that he remain completely random.

Darien's powers are obvious in spite of his youth. He hears voices in the wind "calling him to come and play outside in the wild dark dancing of the storm" (*TWF* 343). They frighten him so he crawls into Finn's bed, who is a great comfort to him and the person he loves most in the world. When Finn leaves to join the Wild Hunt, Darien takes this as a betrayal. Still childlike, he is unable to understand why Finn had to go and abandon him: "He ... lay wide awake, wanting Finn, not understanding how Finn, who was supposed to love him, could have left him all alone" (360). Immediately thereafter, Darien's eyes change colour from their natural blue to red, which happens when he uses his power and is a frightening indication of his parentage. Since his powers come from his father, the parent that was a god, every time Darien's eyes change they seem to indicate the evil and danger that lurk within him.

After Finn leaves, Darien does not remain a boy for long. Paul takes him to the grove of the Summer Tree to request that Cernan, God of the Beasts, give Darien an older body. Paul believes that Darien cannot control his power or make his choice as a child:

“Why?” the god whispered in dismay. “Why was he allowed to live?”

Paul became aware of murmuring among the trees. He remembered it. He said, “To make the choice. The most important choice in all the worlds. But not as a child; his power has come too soon.” ...

“It is only as a child,” Cernan said, “that he can be controlled.”

Paul shook his head. “There is no controlling him, nor could there ever be.

Woodlord, he is a battlefield and must be old enough to know it!” (407)

Unbeknownst to the pair, Darien has overheard all of this, learning the true identity of his father. He has aged himself into an adolescent by using his own power which has been heightened by the power of the Summer Tree. Brendel and Paul try to reason with Darien, and seem to be getting through to him until Paul asks him what Finn told him of love and Darien reacts poorly: “‘He left,’ said Darien, a spasm of pain raking across his face. ‘*He left!*’ the boy cried again” (408). Then Darien disappears to a place where he and Finn used to go and is “deeply angry at everyone” (409). After this point, Darien is largely alone and his loneliness and resentment are what shape him. He does not feel as if he belongs anywhere.

Darien increasingly feels as though he is rejected by the forces of good. The best example of this is when he returns to Ysanne’s cottage and Kim puts the Circlet of Lisen on his brow. Kim, with her Seer’s power, has dreamt that the Circlet will go to Darien, which is why she is down in the secret room where Ysanne kept it. When Darien meets

her there, Kim explains that she knows his mother. When Darien asks if she knows who his father is she confirms that she does and states, “‘He wanted [your mother] to die, so you wouldn’t be born’” (*TDR* 547). Darien “laughed a little, a lonely, terrible laugh. ‘I didn’t know that,’ he said. ‘Cernan asked why I was allowed to live. I heard him. Everyone seems to agree’” (547). Kim assures him that Jennifer wanted him to live but he does not seem comforted and demands she give him the Circlet of Lisen, which she has told him “is the Light against the Dark” (547) and belongs to him. This event only increases Darien’s torment:

It was easy to fit the golden band over his golden hair and close the delicate clasp. It was easy; it had been dreamt; it was done.

And the moment the clasp was fitted the light of the Circlet went out.

A sound escaped him; a torn, wordless cry.... Then Darien made another sound, and this time it was laughter. Not the lost laugh of before, this was harsh, strident, uncontrolled. “Mine?” he cried. ‘The Light against the Dark? Oh, you fool! How should the son of Rakoth Maugrim carry such a light? How should it ever shine for me?’”

Kim’s hands were against her mouth. There was so much unbridled torment in his voice. (547-8).

Darien is clearly tormented by the fact that the Circlet went out on his brow and this seems definitive proof to him that he is of the Dark and has no place with the Light. He steals Lökdal and vows to go to his father.

There seems to be one last chance for Darien to be brought to the Light – when he goes to Jennifer at Lisen’s Tower. He offers Lökdal to Jennifer but she refuses it and

seems to reject him. Darien does not take this well: “Then the boy cried, from the center of his heart, ‘*Don’t you want me?*’” (562). Jennifer is not given the chance to answer before Darien shows off his powers, burning a tree and threatening to go to Maugrim, claiming that she leaves him no other choice. Jennifer is physically unresponsive and only reiterates what she has always said about him:

‘Darien, I leave you the only choice there is. I will say this much and nothing more: you live, though your father wanted me dead so that you would never come into the Tapestry.... There is a choice for you to make, and everything I know tells me that you must make it freely and unconstrained, or it will never have been made at all. If I bind you to me now, or even try, I strip you of what you are.’ (562-3)

Jennifer’s actions seem cold and cruel but she maintains what she always has: that Darien must remain completely free to make his choice and his freedom is her gift to him. Darien does not understand and leaves, determined now that Maugrim will accept him since no one else has. Dena Taylor states that “Jennifer is the only one who loves Darien enough to trust him to make his own choice, and he realizes it at last when he confronts his father, the Unraveller, and makes his choice for the Light.” While Jennifer’s actions seem cruel and Darien certainly feels that they are, in the end they are what influence him the most and drive him to make the right choice.

Darien reaches his father while the final battle rages and Maugrim does not welcome him but instead tries to determine his identity, threatening to kill him once he finds it out. He accepts the gift of the dagger but mocks him for it and Darien is again disappointed. Maugrim demands his name, holding him in thrall psychically: “Darien had come to tell

him. To offer all he was and might be so that someone, somewhere, might be glad of his presence” (734). Maugrim is obviously not glad of his presence, though Darien is suddenly freed to move and see the battlefield below. He sees people he recognizes, his adopted father, Jennifer, Paul, Lancelot, and he thinks of Finn “who had said that Darien was to try to love everything except the Dark” (735) and he finally makes up his mind: “Freely, uncoerced, [Darien] finally numbered himself among [the army of Light]. His eyes were shining, and he knew that they were blue. And so there, in that moment, in the deepest stronghold of the Dark, Darien made his choice” (735). His son’s recognition of Jennifer allows Maugrim to finally understand who Darien is but Darien has already made his choice and impales himself on Lökdal, which Maugrim holds, killing himself and Maugrim at the same time.

It seems almost miraculous that Darien, the boy who experienced love only briefly early in his life and was otherwise rejected and feared, manages to make the right choice. His freedom to make that choice is very important. Tormented though Darien is, Jennifer’s gift to him, to leave him as a random thread, is what tips the balance. The only element more random than Darien is the Wild Hunt, connected to Darien by Finn. It is Darien’s freely chosen self-sacrifice that kills Maugrim, saves Fionavar and all the worlds, and therefore allows for the successful completion of the Pattern. If Darien had not made his choice, if Maugrim had not died, evil would have taken over everything and the Tapestry would have been, for all intents and purposes, ruined. Darien’s choice prevents that outcome. Darien’s self-sacrifice is also the most extreme form of Halbertal’s notion of ‘sacrificing for’: Darien dies not for an individual or for a cause but to ensure the safety of Fionavar and all the worlds that reflect it.

Both Diarmuid and Darien express free will in their choices to sacrifice their lives to save others. In Diarmuid's case, he saves Arthur, Guinevere, and Lancelot from their doom. In Darien's, he saves everyone. While all the other sacrifices in the trilogy that I have discussed in my last two chapters are also freely chosen, there is an element of fate woven into them as well. Diarmuid's and Darien's sacrifices are not fated. There is no mention of any fate for Diarmuid, emphasizing his anarchic nature and that he generally acts extravagantly or unexpectedly. Darien's fate is that he must make the choice between Light and Dark, but which he will choose cannot be foretold. These two sacrifices, more than any of the others, emphasize the theme of the trilogy: the importance of free will in accomplishing a positive destiny. The central theme of *Fionavar* is that willing self-sacrifice is necessary for the successful completion of the Tapestry, that is to say, for the Light to triumph over the Dark.

CONCLUSION

Sacrifice is a broad subject that will continue to be debated by theorists for years to come. My attention to it in this study has been very specific: self-sacrifice as an important action in literature and, specifically, in Guy Gavriel Kay's *Fionavar* trilogy. Kay successfully differentiates himself from Tolkien with the use of sacrifice as a way to change what appears to be fixed destinies. While there is choice in Tolkien's trilogy, Susannah Clements points out that that choice acts as an agent of fate. What I have tried to do in this study is outline how Kay differentiates himself from Tolkien; that his characters' choices disrupt the fixed Pattern and change it for the better. Perhaps the real difference comes down to the fact that the overall plan in Tolkien's world seems benevolent; even though Frodo fails, victory is still ensured. In Kay, the Weaver's Pattern includes darker things such as the perpetual doom of the Arthurian triad and a real price being paid (Rakoth Maugrim) for the option of free will. This means the Weaver's initial World Tapestry is more malevolent. In order for the World Tapestry to be successfully completed, i.e. for good to triumph over evil, willing self-sacrifice is necessary to alter it for the better. I have demonstrated this in a variety of ways in this study.

In my first chapter, I discussed how Paul offers himself as sacrifice on the Summer Tree in *TST*. The main reason for this sacrifice is to end the drought plaguing the land, but it also has two other outcomes. First, by going on the Tree Paul undergoes a transformation that finally allows him to forgive himself for the death of his girlfriend, Rachel, for which he has always felt responsible. Second, Aileron, who later becomes High King, thought that dying on the Tree was supposed to be his destiny. Were this

true, Aileron would not have been present to lead the army of Light against the Dark in the final battle. By “stealing” Aileron’s fate, Paul ensures that Aileron takes his leadership role in the battle, so that good has a better chance of defeating evil. Ysanne’s self-sacrifice in *TST* serves a similar function. She not only gives up her life but also her chance at an afterlife in order for Kim to gain the knowledge and power that will be necessary to take her place as the Seer of Brennin. Kim features in many key moments of the trilogy, not all of which I was able to discuss. Without Ysanne’s sacrifice, her connection with Fionavar would not have been as strong and she would not have been able to perform her various important actions.

In *TWF* and the second chapter of this study, I examined the sacrifices of Finn, Kevin and Matt. If Finn had not stepped up to join the Wild Hunt, Owein may have killed Kim and the other characters present as he was threatening to do. Finn’s acceptance of his fate, his complete willingness to offer himself as sacrifice, saves them. Finn’s joining the Hunt also allows them to intervene at a crucial moment when Dave summons them with Owein’s Horn, winning the battle for them though it also caused many casualties. In spite of that, had Finn not joined the Hunt they would not have been able to ride and the Dalrei would have been slaughtered. Finn’s connection to Laila also figures into his sacrifice. If she had not been able to get through to him after the last battle in *TDR*, Finn and the Hunt would have slaughtered everyone. Because of Laila’s and Finn’s connection and Laila’s own latent powers as a priestess, Finn is able to come back to himself for a moment and attempt to turn away from the Hunt. This throws them into disarray allowing Ruana to come and bind them once more.

Kevin's sacrifice is crucial because it ends the unnatural winter, allowing a group of characters to sail to Cader Sedat and stop Metran and the Cauldron of Khath Meigol. Kevin's sacrifice is also important because, were the voyagers not able to go to Cader Sedat, Arthur would never have been able to waken Lancelot and avoid the doom associated with the traditional Arthurian cycle. Similarly, Matt's sacrifice at the end of *TWF* is the only reason Loren is able to defeat Metran. Lancelot comes into play again here since he brings Matt back to life, allowing Matt to take his rightful place as King of the Dwarves and lead the dwarves away from Rakoth Maugrim. Each sacrifice makes the next possible, which speaks to the necessity of sacrifice in general.

In my third chapter, I discussed the sacrifices of Diarmuid and Darien in *TDR*. While I have been up to this point emphasizing the necessity of self-sacrifice to the successful completion of the overall World Pattern, the idea of choice, that these sacrifices are made willingly, is also important. Diarmuid and Darien best exemplify the importance of choice. While the other sacrifices were in some ways a mixture of free will and fate, Diarmuid's and Darien's sacrifices are freely willed choices with little to no elements of destiny in them. Diarmuid's choice, to take Arthur's place in battle against a deadly foe and his subsequent death, breaks the pattern of the doomed Arthurian triad. Diarmuid changes the weave of the Tapestry with his action and sets Arthur, Lancelot, and Guinevere free. Darien has the most important choice of all, that between Light and Dark. It is because of Jennifer's unwillingness to influence him one way or another that results in him choosing Light and sacrificing himself to save all of the worlds. Choice is never more important than with these two characters and their willingness to sacrifice themselves is so powerful that it alters the design of the World Tapestry for the better.

I believe my study of Kay's trilogy to be useful in a number of ways. No one has paid close attention to the importance of willing self-sacrifice in *Fionavar*. Indeed, there is very little close reading of Kay's works in general which I feel is a major gap in the study of fantasy literature. Kay's works are complex, multi-layered, and have important messages to convey about life and humanity. He is also an important figure in the genre of heroic fantasy literature for demonstrating how works in the genre do not just have to imitate Tolkien's trilogy. He illustrates this point very well in *Fionavar* by taking familiar Tolkienian tropes and expanding or transforming them. Furthermore, Kay moves the idea of willing self-sacrifice out of a religious context and into a more secular idea, which is also in contrast to Tolkien as I have tried to make clear in this study.

The question remains: why is there so little critical work on Kay? Possibly it is because he is a Canadian author and therefore may not have attracted as much attention as his British or American contemporaries. That seems unlikely, however, as his works have been translated into over twenty-five languages and he has won major international awards for his writing. Perhaps the answer lies in the fact that, aside from *Fionavar* and, to a certain extent, *Ysabel* (2007) which is connected to *Fionavar*, his works occupy the somewhat obscure subgenre of historical fantasy. Few have examined this subgenre, and perhaps Kay is neglected critically because no one really knows how to talk about his works when there are so few others to compare them to. George R.R. Martin could also be said to write a form of historical fantasy, since he does base his series on British history, but most of Kay's historical fantasy is specifically focused on a certain time period. It would be difficult to contrast Martin's and Kay's work solely in generic terms.

Regardless, further critical work on Kay is necessary to the study of fantasy literature because he tries to expand upon common fantasy tropes and change them in a variety of ways. The difference in worldview between Kay's *Fionavar* trilogy and Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* is only one of these ways. The complexity of Kay's writing, and the breadth of his oeuvre make Kay's works a fascinating subject for critical analysis, as I hope this study has made clear.

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